

**“Bless Me Father, For I Have Sinned”;
(Re)Constructing Catholic Confession Through Embodied Experiences**

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ABSTRACT

Over 1.3 billion people are baptized members of the Catholic Church, including myself. Though all Catholics participate in confession— a repeated practice of disclosing their sins to a priest, in exchange for God’s forgiveness— the sacrament has never been analyzed within sociology. This study takes a critical approach to confession, and the Church; mapping the ritual’s power through systematic, embodied interactions. Sociologists situate analogous religious and institutional practices as experiences of total subjectivity, describing external domination or internal spirituality. However, over 50 hours of ethnographic interviews with 32 Catholic priests and parishioners reveal the recursive structure of confession, as members’ bodies both (re)shape, and are (re)shaped by the Church’s moral logic. Using personalized discursive frames, interviewees locate (im)morality on and within their lived bodies as a corporeal “part” of them. Unique descriptions of sin and forgiveness as somatic sensations demonstrate how confession relies on interviewees’ embodied agency. This phenomenological analysis argues that the ritual facilitates an interdependent relationship between penitents and the Church, who work together to ensure their mutual survival. Confession provides a *living* sociological framework to study how moralized bodily practices (re)produce institutional power through corporeal transformations in which agents are fully complicit.

PROLOGUE: “... YOU KNOW?”

This study examines the embodied experiences of Catholic priests and lay parishioners with the Church’s sacrament of confession— or *Penance and Reconciliation*. Though these findings are generalizable to other institutions and their bodily practices, the Catholic Church and confession are an incredibly specific empirical case. This analysis is laden with specific histories, languages, and structures, which can only be understood completely through the lived experience of Church membership. I was baptized at five years old, and attended Catholic schools until ninth grade. Every week, I attended Mass several times with my peers and immediate family. Though I no longer identify as a practicing member, I regularly participated in confession, and other Church practices throughout the overwhelming majority of my lifetime. This intimate, practical knowledge of the Church, and the potency of these experiences are precisely why I selected this case. My Catholic upbringing provided a detailed preview of both the institution and confession, making me confident in the value of examining both through a critical, sociological lens.

These data and subsequent analysis are especially ethnographic, as I foregrounded my Catholic identity while interviewing priests and parishioners. Recognizing my own embodied knowledge often truncated our communication, and led them to abbreviate critical details about the ritual. Throughout our conversations, interviewees frequently alluded to common experiences and doctrinal logic by rhetorically asking me, “...you know?” While their embodied accounts were rich and vivid, interviewees’ explanations were sometimes cut short by our shared [practical] understanding of the Church. Through my institutional fluency, I did in fact “know” about the phenomena interviewees described, and could often reference similar experiences of my own. Alone, these data are incredibly powerful. However, in preliminary discussions of this

research, I discovered a striking affective difference in how it is received; individuals with deeper knowledge of the Church and confession, like myself, are able to engage this analysis on a somatic level. Interviewees' embodied experiences of confession are not only empirical findings, but also visceral reminders of personal experiences "trading sins like baseball cards."¹

Through individuals' corporeal memory, these data *come alive*. Interviewees' accounts and the theoretical conclusions I draw from them are fundamentally interactional, and as a result, must be understood through interaction. These data do not simply reflect priests' and parishioners' "recollections", but rather their dynamic corporeal experiences of confession. By describing their lives in the Church, interviewees demonstrate how the Church lives in and through their bodies. These phenomenological accounts demand– and deserve– active engagement, and courageous reflexivity. Throughout this analysis, interviewees' embodied experiences come alive, because the institution also lives in me. However, these findings are not exclusive to Catholics or the Church, and delineate a fluid model of power that is wholly transferable and transposable. Interviewees' experiences live in all of us; somatically accessible through the lens of institutional structures already embodied, and (re)produced in a wide range of social contexts. This study posits a generalizable structure of confession as the open-ended, recursive, and systematic interaction of corporeal and institutional schemas. By tracing the functional (re)production of interviewees' unique subjectivity in the Church, I delineate a critical account of power and agency; arguing the interdependent relationship between them is entirely organized by and through the body.

¹ My profound gratitude to Dr. Joseph Verschaeve, who shared this anecdote. Thank you for showing me the gift of our discipline, your inspiring professionalism, and goodness. I will never forget your class!

INTRODUCTION

... it's a part of me, and maybe I just want to make it part of me...of course I'm going to go to confession, because it's a part of who I am, that's how I take on the world...
- Elizabeth, lay parishioner

While over 1.3 billion people are part of the Catholic Church, this study argues that the Catholic Church is part of over 1.3 billion people. The institution's beliefs and practices are entirely centered around members' bodies—relying on their appearance, capacity, and function as tangible evidence of faithfulness. Baptized or not, both Catholics and non-Catholics are cognizant of the Church's corporeal infrastructure because of its near constant presence in social consciousness and discourse. Given its pervasiveness, sociologists ought to consider that the most conclusive evidence of the Church's power is not financial, political, or even spiritual— but rather, it is *embodied*². Through a variety of everyday, informal interactions and more sacred, formal “sacraments”³, members (re)shape themselves in the image of God, and the Church. Though all members participate in these compulsory practices, specific Catholic rituals have yet to be analyzed in connection to the institution's broader power— rarely examining the Church from an empirical perspective at all, much less an embodied one.

This study takes a critical approach to this phenomenon by analyzing Catholic priests' and parishioners' lived experiences with the sacrament of confession. For interviewees, this ritual cannot be reduced to an ephemeral spiritual encounter. Rather, as Elizabeth— a lifelong Catholic— articulated, confession is *a part of them*. The Church's institutional logic is embodied as a tangible extension of their ontological being; (re)shaping individuals both morally, and corporeally. Interviewees discuss how (im)morality feels, describing sin and forgiveness as

² In recent years, the Church has garnered significant public scrutiny for its role in pervasive child sexual abuse. Public knowledge of the institution and how it centers members' bodies is dominated by such accounts. However, as this study argues, there are several other, less explicit examples of corporeal control within the Church.

³ See the subsection entitled, *The Roman Catholic Church: A Brief Introduction*, for a more in-depth explanation of Catholic “sacraments” and belief practices.

somatic sensations. This ethnographic analysis argues that these experiences are direct, embodied evidence of the Church's institutional power. Through the ritual's transformational structure, (im)morality is simultaneously located by and in the lived body. Interviewees describe how sin diminishes their physical appearance and well-being in various ways that confession allows them to address. Catholic teaching asserts that the ritual is always effective, because God's forgiveness is unconditional; freely offered by the Church, and reliably experienced by its members⁴.

However, these interview data vitiate this narrative entirely. Priests and parishioners describe the precarious performances of their respective roles as confessors and penitents; where failure to complete the complex corporeal labor required by the ritual may diminish, or preclude God's forgiveness altogether. Barring practical complications, confession transforms sinful penitents into moral individuals who have [hopefully] been absolved. Interviewees reflect on the efficacy of this process using different narrative frameworks to locate (im)morality on or within their lived bodies. For some, sin occupies an external presence, as burdens, weight, dirt, or stains that are removed from their corporeal being through confession. For others, sin is internal, and fully embodied as psychological and physiological ailments, disabilities, illnesses, and injuries treated and healed through the ritual. By identifying these sensations as embodied evidence of sinfulness, interviewees effectively define confession as a freeing, cleansing, or healing process.

In all of these descriptions, the lived body is a practical locus that (re)orients individuals according to the degree to which they feel and observe their (im)morality somatically. While forgiveness may never be actualized, it is always concretized— or better yet, *corporealized*— through the embodied reactions demanded and provoked by confession. Interviewees describe their transformations as “tangible,” producing visceral effects and “physical sensation[s].”

⁴ Chapter 2, article 4, paragraph 1422 of the *Catechism of the Catholic Church* describes the [certainty of] “pardon” God offers penitents through confession (p. 357).

*... I couldn't tell you how many times I have left the confessional just feeling like the weight of the world is off my shoulders... **for me, it has been about as close to a physical sensation as you can imagine.** That experience of having that weight lifted, is **tangible...** that's what it feels like. – Matt, lay parishioner*

These data reveal how and where individuals identify sin as corporeal sensations, intrinsic to their lived bodies. The ritual provides forgiveness that allows penitents to feel lighter and cleaner, or be healthier and more attractive; establishing confession as necessary to preserve their moral and physiological well-being. Naturalizing sin as a bodily condition or state necessitates complete dependence on the Church for both spiritual and actual survival—ensuring its long term legitimacy and viability. By describing their embodied experiences of sin, interviewees thereby define their embodied relationship to the institution; revealing how the ritual structures their symbiotic interdependence. This study argues that confession is therefore essential for the *mutual* survival of both the Church as a powerful institution, and individuals as living, healthy, and moral bodies.

Despite its systematic organization, this relationship is not statically (re)productive of a uniform subjectivity, embodied by all interviewees in the same way. Instead, it is continuously (re)structured to fit their individual bodies exactly, and takes a variety of corporeal forms. The diverse frames of forgiveness as freedom, cleansing, and healing demonstrate confession's fluidity. Interviewees' unique constructions of their embodied relation to sin and the Church are (re)shaped by their individual agency, allowing the ritual to exhibit several different structural properties at once. Fluctuating and even incongruent experiences are not only possible, but also necessary to assert confession's unbounded and unlimited [institutional] power; where the same ritual can plausibly provide forgiveness experienced as lightness by some, and profound physiological healing by others.

The sacraments, and other Catholic practices, have never been analyzed from an embodied empirical perspective. Religious rituals, in general, are often superficially understood as abstract, spiritual moments of corporeal transcendence. However, prior sociological analyses of these phenomena reveal the role of bodily practice in (re)producing religious beliefs and institutions. In other contexts, some studies describe [non-Catholic] rituals as impersonal mechanisms of domination that preclude free, intentional action. Conversely, an opposing strand of literature depicts them as entirely subjective, internal experiences, separate from the organizational contexts and structures they exist within; falsely conflating embodied moral transformations with religious belief. While these analytical perspectives differ greatly, both situate [moralized] institutional practices outside individuals as external and rigid structures that surround them, and over which they have no control. These frameworks have similar implications, suggesting that rituals are an experience of total embodied subjectivity. I argue that confession is neither of these absolutes. Instead, these data demonstrate how the ritual functions as an institutional mechanism of corporeal control that is actively (re)produced and enhanced by individual agency.

Unlike existing studies of similar religious and secular practices, I define confession's structure as an embodied, fluid, and recursive interaction that systematically integrates corporeal and institutional *schemas*. I do not operationalize prior structuralist definitions of these terms, or analyze epistemological debates about their suitability. Rather, I conceptualize schemas as engaged individual and institutional logics that (re)shape agents' identities, interactions, and relationships. Through the ritual, interviewees come to understand their (im)morality as essentially embodied through a series of prescribed practices—describing their *corporeal* schemas through somatic sensations of sin, external or internal to their lived bodies. By defining

the function of confession to free, cleanse, or heal them from sin, interviewees also identify the analogous *institutional* schema of the Church, demonstrating how its moral logic of sin structures the ritual. Through confession, priests and parishioners systematically create and (re)produce these structures, (re)shaping them to fit their lived bodies. As an inherent structural component of their corporeal schema, penitents learn that to sin is to exist, and to exist is to sin; thus, being within the Church becomes the only way of being in the social and physical world. By locating (im)morality on and within their bodies in various ways, interviewees' experiences effectively demonstrate how corporeal and institutional structures are enmeshed through confession; as the schemas of individuals and the Church become fully indistinguishable, and continuously (re)produce one another.

This reflexive three-pronged analysis draws from phenomenology, critical theory, and structuralist perspectives to demonstrate the duality of confession as a recursive interaction between penitents and the Church. Embodied experiences with the ritual reveal its functional (re)production of this relationship, as individuals and the institution work together to ensure their mutual survival. Though I describe confession through a language of structure, I do not contend that this interaction— or the requisite schemas it combines— are homologous, terminal, or consistently result in a uniform subjectivity embodied by all penitents. Rather, I use these terms to map the interdependent relationship between penitents and the Church; describing how the ritual facilitates an interaction between individual and institutional through a series of prescribed bodily practices. Rather than a closed “system,” I describe the overarching process of the ritual as fundamentally *systematic* in its continuous and strategic cultivation of diverse subjectivities—the specific form and qualities of which are determined by the agents who embody them. The personalized narrative frameworks interviewees employ reveal how they participate in the ritual

as corporeally knowledgeable agents; (re)producing their relationship with the Church as unique structures grafted to, and shaped by their lived bodies.

Grounded in a phenomenological approach, this study begins at the level of individual embodiment, examining how Catholic priests and lay parishioners experience confession. Interviewees' ethnographic accounts allow the ritual to 'speak for itself', comparing how it functions in practice, to how the Catholic Church explains and justifies its purpose. Finally, I examine the interdependent, fluid dynamic between interviewees' embodied schemas of agency and subjectivity to understand how confession structures their relationship with the Church. These data define four dimensions of the ritual's overarching structure; revealing how penitents' relationship with the Church is (1) centered around the lived body, (2) laden with institutional power, (3) recursively (re)structured, and (4) continuously (re)shaped by individual agency. This critical turn advances current sociological understandings of the lived body, religious rituals, institutional power, and Catholicism by theorizing a dynamic model of confession, as the systematic integration of both corporeal and institutional structures.

Embracing the highest degree of methodological subjectivity paradoxically culminates in the empirical objectivity of these data. This analysis does not seek to aggregate, homogenize, or reduce the experience of confession to either individual, or institutional interpretations. Rather, I address the central questions of this study using phenomenological data obtained through over 50 hours of extensive, semi-structured interviews with 32 Catholic priests and parishioners in two midwestern Catholic Dioceses, comprised of several mid-sized towns and cities. The ethnographic quality of these interviews is enhanced by their unique format and context. With a few virtual exceptions, all conversations took place at individuals' home parishes. Interviewees thus articulated their lived experiences with confession and the Church in physical environments

laden with signifiers of both the ritual, and institution. The highly personal substance of these discussions demanded an intense dyadic vulnerability, embodied by both interviewees and myself. Collecting and analyzing this data was not merely a reflective experience, but an intensely reflexive one as well. As someone who was raised Catholic, I have been to confession myself, countless times. Sharing this aspect of my identity with interviewees made our interpersonal connection both more immediate, and complex; as the process of understanding the ritual's embodied effects became an expressly mutual endeavor. Through interactions with interviewees, I became intimately aware of how my own body was inscribed with the Church's moral logic in confession, and the institution more broadly. Rather than an analytical burden, my embodied knowledge further enhances the uniquely ethnographic character of these data.

Among existing literature, this study is distinguished by the thorough alignment of its objectives, methods, and theoretical framework. Through a critical lens, this study maps how corporeal and institutional schemas of (im)morality are integrated and (re)produced through confession. I argue that individuals and the institution are reflexively bound to each other through the ritual, working together to ensure their mutual survival. Through a theory of confession's recursive structure, this analysis demonstrates how penitents dually (re)shape and are (re)shaped by the Church's moral logic of sin. Confession therefore provides a *living* sociological framework to study how moralized bodily practices within other religious and secular contexts (re)produce institutional power through corporeal transformations in which agents are fully complicit.

SETTING

As a systematic integration of corporeal and institutional schemas, the ritual's essential structural qualities are determined in part by the Church—(re)shaped by its specific moral logic and practices, or schema. While interviewees' accounts and experiences are distinctly individual, they are also (re)formed through an underlying framework of embodied knowledge, exclusive to the Church. These dually ethnographic data demonstrate this framework in two ways, structuring interviewees' somatic accounts discursively and practically. The specific language and organization of the Church are critical to understanding both their embodied experiences, and embodied descriptions of confession. This interaction models a general structure of how agency and power are related through systematic bodily practice, that is transferable outside the context of Catholicism. However, I observe this interaction through the particular case of confession— a ritual unique to the Catholic Church and faith with deep institutional roots. It is therefore critical to first understand the context in which the ritual is (re)structured. With adequate background information about the institution's logic and structure, confession's analytical value becomes legible, accessible, and applicable to a wide range of agents, organizations, and other embodied interactions between them.

The Roman Catholic Church: A Brief Introduction

As an organized religious sect, the Catholic Church relies on a robust moral infrastructure. Life in the Church is scaffolded by a specialized logic that shapes virtually every aspect of how members exist in the social and physical world. Well-established rules inform and regulate their actions, feelings, thoughts, perceptions, and relationships. Though structured beliefs and practices are characteristic of religion generally, Catholicism is distinguished from other [Christian] denominations by its especially formal and rigid traditions. Catholic prayers

and rituals are tightly structured by predetermined scripts for individual and institutional action. Members can only be “full” or “real” Catholics when they demonstrate adequate knowledge of their respective roles and responsibilities by adhering to the Church’s expectations; both in form and frequency. These standards influence members’ participation in rituals and momentary instantiations of belief that require specific (embodied) performances. Beyond isolated experiences, the Church also structures the course of Catholics’ lives as a whole through the seven “sacraments”; Baptism, Penance and Reconciliation, Eucharist, Confirmation, Anointing of the Sick, Matrimony, and Holy Orders. These rites map members’ moral and corporeal development, progressively signifying their elevation to a more sophisticated faith, and higher institutional status.

While only some are required for membership, completing more sacraments is associated with a greater degree of religiosity, and intimacy with God. Sacraments are distinguished from other belief practices by their diverse structures and functions; resisting any formal or temporal homogenization. However, they all share the same, general objective of transformation—providing an exclusive opportunity for members to receive God’s “grace” which enhances or redeems their moral characters. Some are celebrated once as distinct events in members’ faith journey, while others are ritualistic and must be repeated often to remain in good standing with the Church. Certain singular, and routine sacraments are prerequisites for others, and must be administered in a particular order. Each of these ceremonies, anointments, and regular rituals occur at particular times throughout members’ lives, to address their stage of moral development. “Cradle Catholics”, who were born and raised in the faith, celebrate sacraments at certain ages and grade-levels. Adults who convert later in life complete them in the same fixed sequence at an accelerated pace, during their initiation through an RCIA program (Rights of Catholic Initiation

for Adults). Regardless of when they occur, priests' and parishioners' bodies are central to the sacraments, as both agents and targets of transformation.

Understanding Confession: Sinful Humanity

"Penance and Reconciliation" is the second sacrament members receive, though it is more commonly known as "confession." The Church prefers the formal term of "reconciliation" to sidestep intimidating connotations of judgment. However, members often call the ritual "confession" to colloquially reference the action it requires; the confession of one's sins. The Church's objective of moral transformation is most explicit in this sacrament, as it is intended to address members' immorality— or sins— by offering God's forgiveness. Those raised in the Church usually celebrate this rite for the first time in second grade, or when they are seven to eight years old. After their "First Reconciliation," members are not only able, but expected to celebrate the sacrament repeatedly, on a regular basis. The Church teaches that to be human, is to sin. Mortal beings are inherently imperfect, and condemned to a lifetime of moral failures. Perpetually prone to wrongdoing, members are always in need of God's forgiveness— and thus also, confession. Other Christian denominations question this logic, arguing individuals do not need a priest or formal ritual to access absolution, and can "confess" their sins to God through direct prayer. The Church responds to such criticism by differentiating between two kinds of sins, distinguished by the degree of immorality such acts involve. Individuals can only receive forgiveness from God directly for *venial* sins; small, unserious, or unintended immoral actions with limited consequences. However, if individuals want to be forgiven of all their sins, they must also go to confession. The sacrament is defined as the exclusive and sole opportunity to be absolved of *mortal* sins; the most grave, serious, and intentional offenses individuals knowingly commit. The Church thus argues human beings are not only prone to sin, but the worst kind of

sin, which requires institutional assistance and intervention. In this way, confession provides the forgiveness individuals need the most, and necessarily cannot live without.

Practicing Confession: Forgiveness in Three Steps

Just as personal prayers are insufficient for total absolution, so too is simply disclosing sins to a priest. The complex, embodied practices entailed by the ritual, further restrict access to God's forgiveness. Catholics must adhere to a specific procedure that structures their verbal and nonverbal participation at each of the three steps in the confessional process. Second-graders, adult converts, and priests themselves receive extensive instruction, and repeatedly practice this script before celebrating the sacrament "officially"; memorizing particular actions and dialogue. Oftentimes— especially in Catholic schools and seminaries— members participate in mock confessions to rehearse their roles ahead of time, constructing hypothetical sins and scenarios. This valuable practice ensures their successful *performance* of an actual confession, with knowledge of how to act, speak, and even feel "the right way" at specific moments throughout the ritual. These scripts delineate two roles; members are "penitents," asking for forgiveness, while priests are "confessors" imbued with the divine authority to offer it on God's behalf.

The sacrament occurs in three steps or stages, each demarcated by their spiritual function and purpose. Before Catholics can apologize for their sins, they must first identify what they are apologizing for. The first step is an "examination of conscience." Through deep introspection, penitents review their past actions to identify (recent) moral failures and transgressions. Though this impromptu preparation is entirely self-directed, the Church offers several guides to guarantee individuals find something to confess. These pamphlets, videos, and other resources suggest "common" offenses they likely committed as a result of human immorality, even if they have no personal recollections of doing so. Ideally, penitents emerge from this prayerful reflection with a

finite list— memorized or written— of sins to confess, and *explain* in number and kind; able to elaborate on each, if questioned further by the priest. With the rest of the script “filled-in,” penitents can proceed to the second step of actually disclosing their sins, and asking for forgiveness. Most parishes offer the ritual in two interpersonal formats, allowing members to choose between speaking with the priest face-to-face, or from behind a traditional screen. After entering the private confessional room, penitents kneel and address the priest by reciting;

Bless me, Father, for I have sinned. It has been [a specific length of time in days, months, or years] since my last confession. These are my sins...

After disclosing everything on their list, penitents apologize with genuine contrition by stating;

For these, and all my sins, I am truly sorry.

During seminary, priests are trained as confessors to develop their own listening “styles” and strategies. Some discuss the details of penitents’ sins further, and ask clarifying questions. Others get straight to the point, and assign penance— the specific, restorative actions and prayers individuals must complete after confession to make up for the damage caused by their sins. Depending on the severity and nature of individuals’ confessions, penance may take several different forms. Some confessors take an impersonal approach, assigning a set number of specific prayers (i.e. three “Hail Marys”). Others are more individualized, and direct penitents to apologize to specific people, or incorporate new habits into their spiritual routine. However, priests do not prescribe penance at their own discretion. The Church teaches that confessors act *in persona Christi*, or *in the person of Christ*. As a result, penitents do not really confess to a human man, but to God Himself— present in the form of the priest, whose own agency, judgment, and knowledge is bypassed by divine intervention. Everything priests say and do ostensibly represents God’s response to penitents, rather than their personal thoughts and feelings. Confessors are empowered by the sacrament of Priesthood to hear and discuss sins, and assign

analogous penances. They are not empowered, however, to counsel penitents through the ritual; as the Church firmly disapproves of using confession for psychological comfort or therapy.

After receiving their penance, individuals pray the Act of Contrition. The version I learned as a second grade student preparing for my First Reconciliation, is reproduced below. However, members may learn several variations of this prayer, depending on their generation and geographic location.

My God, I am sorry for my sins with all my heart. In choosing to do wrong and failing to do good, I have sinned against you whom I should love above all things. I firmly intend, with your help, to do penance, to sin no more, and to avoid whatever leads me to sin. Our Savior Jesus Christ suffered and died for us. In his name, my God, have mercy. Amen.

Finally, God forgives penitents' sins through the priest, who recites the prayer of absolution. If confessors deviate from this exact language, they invalidate the sacrament and God's forgiveness—leaving penitents' moral transformation incomplete.

God, the Father of mercies, through the death and resurrection of his Son has reconciled the world to himself and sent the Holy Spirit among us for the forgiveness of sins; through the ministry of the Church may God give you pardon and peace, and I absolve you from your sins in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit... The Lord has freed you from your sins. Go in Peace.

Penitents respond, *Thanks be to God*, and leave the confessional. Immediately after exiting the room, individuals are expected to complete their penance; either by reciting their assigned prayers in the church, or repairing specific relationships. Individuals are only able to experience God's forgiveness and the "graces" of the sacrament upon finishing their penance.

In order for the sacrament to be celebrated successfully, it must conform to this detailed format and structure. God's forgiveness is entirely dependent on the ability of confessors and penitents to perform all verbal and nonverbal aspects of their respective roles, as defined by the Church. However, Catholic teaching of humans' inherent fallibility makes this highly unlikely,

contradicting the ritual's espoused logic. My own experiences as a penitent confirm the virtual impossibility of a seamless performance. Each confession was plagued by nuanced variances that troubled me greatly. *Did I confess [well] enough? Were all of my sins forgiven?* These lingering doubts persisted even after the most structurally sound confessions, often leading me to recite additional prayers for penance— in an effort to be sure I repaid the full cost of my immoral actions. Priests and parishioners who participated in this study recall similar feelings and experiences throughout the ritual, articulating an embodied sense of irresolvable sinfulness and (im)morality. Understanding the Church's definition of confession's ideal form and effect, provides a stable metric against which individual, subjective experiences can be comparatively analyzed. Discrepancies in its logic and varied (mis)constructions provide valuable insight into how the ritual's latent effects (re)shape Catholics' identities, perceptions, and relationships, on a corporeal level. This analysis reveals how confession orients sin within priests' and parishioners' bodies, and thus also (re)orients their bodies within the Church.

EPISTEMOLOGY

The body is the central locus of confession, and this study. All parts of the ritual are fundamentally corporeal; from the labor it demands, to the moral transformations it facilitates. Interviewees describe somatic sensations, and even aesthetic appearances, as evidence of their (im)morality; orienting sin externally or internally by observing the visceral changes it produces. As an intensely embodied interaction, confession can only be defined through interviewees' experiences of the ritual. Father Peter, a former social scientist and researcher, makes a compelling case for this methodological perspective, arguing the ritual is inherently “undefinable” through simple explanations.

*I can't tell you anymore... there's always a desire to **define the undefinable**. But **some experiences come only with the experience of them**. - Father Peter, priest of over 10 years*

The doubly ethnographic quality of these data satisfy the ritual's epistemological demands; in essence, interviewees provide embodied accounts of embodied experiences. In addition to confession itself, the act of describing the ritual is an engaged practice that (re)produces bodily effects. In this way, interviewees not only describe, but also demonstrate confession's (re)construction in and through their bodies. This unique form of empirical knowledge is only accessible through the methodological approach of phenomenology; observing the body "in action," as dynamic and *living* evidence of institutional power.

Phenomenology and the Lived Body

Rather than a momentary instantiation of religious belief or institutional power, confession is a phenomenon— a unique, continuous experience whose hidden practical function and structure can only be uncovered through objective self-expression (Heidegger 1962). By articulating the ritual's function through individual accounts, this study follows other sociological inquiries in responding to Heidegger's cogent methodological plea for definition by demonstration; "to the things themselves!" (Heidegger 1962:58). This study's inherently phenomenological approach allows confession to reveal itself through itself, as the ritual's structure and implications are expressed through interviewees' actual experiences. The embodied nature of these data, however, demands a more dynamic conceptualization of corporeality. Instead of a dichotomous division between subject and object— the "psychical" mind and physiological body— this analysis delineates a reflexive corporeal schema of being. Merleau-Ponty describes this *lived body* as an integrated locus that encompasses action, intention, and consciousness; existing as a phenomenological experience of time and space, as

opposed to an object in time and space. The lived body is a means of continuous comprehension and interaction that dually shapes, and is shaped by the social and physical world. This perspective produces a unique ontological and corporeal cartography of individuals' whole being, which effectively (re)orients them in the 'here and now' (Merleau-Ponty [1945] 2014).

Embodied Empirical Perspectives

The phenomenological construction of the lived body is the subject of substantial sociological interest and investigation. Though the value of an embodied perspective is widely acknowledged, existing studies are demarcated by the degree to which they engage individual corporeality as evidence of larger power dynamics. The critical depth and breadth of these analyses is determined by the methodological framework through which they define the body's inherent reflexivity; recognizing individuals as credible authors and subjects of their own lived experiences. Empiricist studies examine the body from the greatest analytical distance, skeptical of its agentic capacity and trustworthiness. Advocates for this perspective argue verbal accounts of corporeality are never empirically valid, and obscure social phenomena by tainting them with attitudinal fallacy— the conflation of attitudes and behaviors (Jerolmack and Kahn 2014). This approach is inherently self-contradictory in its examination of an empirical object, rather than an empirical subject. These studies do not analyze the body as essentially *living*, and sever the observance of opaque, material corporeality from the body's inherent phenomenological capacity. By contrast, this project focuses exclusively on the bodily indicators individuals experience throughout confession, as evidence of the Church's power. These emotions, thoughts, and somatic sensations are valid precisely because the only accurate knowledge of them is exclusively embodied by the same individual tasked with their articulation.

Other scholars employ a more tentative methodological approach to the lived body, as opposed to flatly denying its empirical validity. Mind-body holism seeks to integrate cognitivist and intuitionist conceptions of embodied agency, knowledge, and morality (Hitlin 2010a). These studies address postmodernist concern for dichotomous constructions of the body as an aggregate of (two) distinct parts; the psychological, and the physical. To refute this corporeal binary, scholars focus on the holistic inscription of institutional power on the body as an integrated whole. However, this framework only outlines the disciplinary role of discursive and dialogical—rather than embodied—structures and practices (see Garcia 2010; Ignatow 2009; Johnson 2010; Kurri and Wahlström 2001; and Powell et al. 2017). Though this perspective does not acknowledge the full phenomenological scope of corporeality, it does not preclude critical, substantive analysis. Foucault’s examination of “psychiatric power” – a context-specific form of the “disciplinary power” he theorizes— identifies the body as the principal target of subjectivation. As opposed to phenomenological methods, however, Foucault’s “archeological” analysis traces the “apparatus” of institutional power as purely discursive mechanisms (Foucault et al. [1973-4] 2008).

The Phenomenology of Confession

Foucauldian “archeology” broaches the threshold of phenomenology by identifying the systematic cultivation of a particular embodied subjectivity. However, the corporeal schema is clearest through the application of this methodological framework in its purest form.

Phenomenology attaches knowledge of the body to the body, directly; as its structure and function can only be ascertained when experienced in the living world (Merleau-Ponty [1945] 2014). Giddens’s structuration theory materializes this abstract, Heideggarian corporeality, and analyzes its (re)production in practice. This full-bodied analysis reflects the most complete

conceptualization of embodied subjectivity by locating structure *internally* (Giddens 1984). Institutional power is integrated as an operable extension of individuals' ontological and bodily schema, co-constitutive of their lived reality, rather than terminally or unilaterally productive of instantaneous docility. This study's enhanced critical methodology extends current sociological analyses of the corporeal (re)inscription of institutional power through religious ritual (see Glassman 2017; Guhin 2021; Krotofil et al. 2021; Mahmood 2012; Mellor and Shilling 2014; Winchester 2008). Interviewees' experiences with confession map the Church's power through their interactions within the ritual. By dissecting their lived accounts, this study employs exclusively phenomenological methods to expose the hidden cultivation and experience of embodied subjectivity in practice; uncovering the role of both the institution, and individuals' own agency in its systematic (re)production.

LITERATURE REVIEW

The general phenomenon of confession has been critically examined as a mechanism of institutional power “centered on life,” designed specifically for bodily management and transformation (Foucault [1976] 1990:144). In the context of sexual discourse, Foucault analyzes how this obligatory act of speech (re)produces “intrinsic modifications” in those who disclose privileged information about themselves ([1976] 1990:62). The discursive ritual of confession is structured by an embodied imbalance of power, in which only “he who listens but does not speak” exercises agency (Foucault [1976] 1990:62). However, sociologists have yet to study the *religious* ritual of Catholic confession through a similar critical, and phenomenological lens. A significant vein of current research theorizes the Church's power from economic, and rationalist perspectives to examine its material enrichment and expansion (Abend 2016; Arruñada 2009;

Tentler 1977). By contrast, other analyses of Catholicism focus on how the institution powerfully improves members' well-being, finding that they exhibit more positive attitudes and dispositions after participating in certain sacraments (Bales 2006; Beste 2011).

With the exception of this final strand of literature, existing studies identify a variety of phenomena structurally analogous to confession; both as larger demonstrations of moral power, and corporeal control more generally. Sociologists provide detailed accounts of how systematic bodily practices function to (re)shape individuals within specific religious and secular institutions, to preserve their social legitimacy and viability. Current analyses describe this interaction using different methodologies, and begin at either the level of external structures, or their corporeal effects. Studies of institutional scaffolding depict bodily practices as impersonal mechanisms of domination. Others trace these dynamics through individuals' lived realities, and situate [primarily religious] rituals as wholly internal and intangible experiences. Regardless of how directly they engage the body as empirical evidence of power, all describe how it is functionally transformed through interactions like confession. By focusing on either institutional or corporeal structures separately, prior analyses depict this general phenomenon as an experience of total subjectivity; describing how individuals' bodies are autonomously transformed through practices in which they unwillingly or unwittingly participate. Through the lens of confession's dual structure— composed of both institutional and corporeal schemas— this study integrates existing critical and phenomenological perspectives to theorize its recursivity, as the systematic integration of penitents' embodied agency and subjectivity.

Moral Sensations: (Re)Producing the Lived Body Through Religious Rituals

As a religious organization, the Catholic Church's authority is distinctly *moral*. This form of power is especially potent because it establishes an unbreakable, embodied link between

personal beliefs and institutional logic through prescribed practices like confession. Religious organizations rely on these rituals to not only define what (im)morality means, but also demonstrate how it looks and feels through “good,” “right,” and “worthy” bodies (Rotolo 2020). These strategic expressions of belief require individuals’ active participation, and make them complicit in their own corporeal (re)formation (Hitlin 2010b). Religious rituals are explicitly structured to extract (im)morality from the lived body; defining physical changes as evidence of more profound, spiritual transformations. These moralized corporeal interactions are key moments in which institutional power is (re)produced, both within specific religious hierarchies, and the social world more broadly (Mellor and Shilling 2014).

Sociologists examine embodied “rites” as a fundamental component of “religious forces” that discipline individual and group consciousness through homogenous movement (Durkheim et al. [1912]2008). These practices organize members in relation to one another by “unsettling” their self-concept, and redefining it through the embodied lens of faithfulness (Hill 2020). Forcing adherents to “come out of themselves” thereby provides religious institutions with a continuous means of (re)constitution and regulation (Durkheim et al. [1912]2008:175). Rituals effectively impose system on “untidy” beings and existence through corporeal enrichment and modification. Throughout these processes, the somatic boundaries of members’ individual bodies become synonymous with the symbolic boundaries of the religious community, and a danger to one necessarily endangers the other. The discursive and practical structures of rituals are specifically and strategically developed to preserve a particular institutional order that relates form to function. Abstract beliefs are given meaning, and *brought to life* through their inscription on faithful bodies, “purified” of moral “uncleanliness” (Douglas [1996] 2002).

While scholars agree moral power is fundamentally embodied, they dispute how rituals functionally facilitate its embodiment; constructing institutional and individual roles in (re)producing members' subjectivity, differently. Three general perspectives emerge in current literature that define rituals as (1) disembodied social mechanisms of domination, (2) pseudo-embodied instruments of passive compliance, or (3) wholly embodied and internal subjective experiences. Similar to studies in analogous secular contexts, each of these posit different arguments as to not only how, but also *why* religious institutions require bodily practices; uncovering their functional purpose by observing either external characteristics, or members' lived experiences. By framing them as tools for preserving broad power through (1) autonomous structures, or (2) unconscious embodied compliance, or (3) entirely innocent opportunities for spiritual enrichment, these analyses all characterize rituals as experiences of total subjectivity.

Despite their espoused purposes of facilitating personal growth and transformations, the first strand of this literature asserts that the sole function of rituals is to (re)produce power; legitimizing and sustaining religious institutions through their members' corporeal forms. As outward expressions of spirituality, sociologists examine how these practices provide valuable opportunities for adherents to demonstrate their commitment to religious institutions, by making their bodies morally legible. This study builds on prior analyses of religious bodily practices as mechanisms of systematic social control and domination, through which larger hierarchies of authority are (re)constructed (Glassman 2017; Guhin 2021; Mahmood 2012). Covering, fasting, prayer, and other acts of worship effectively test adherents' corporeal capacities to embody the specific logic of various institutions. Existing studies describe how religious rituals create observable metrics to measure members' moral deservingness by their performances of

faithfulness (Glassman 2017). Symbolic evaluations of their institutional legibility as spiritual belief orient them within broader structures according to their corporeal status. The dynamics these practices (re)produce may be confined to certain churches, schools, and faith communities (Guhin 2021), or represent entire social ideologies of [patriarchal] oppression (Mahmood 2012). Regardless of the scale and scope of the subjectivity they entail, religious rituals expose otherwise overwhelming and unobservable power structures through their lived effects on adherents' bodies. Similar to analyses in secular contexts (Garcia 2010; Johnson 2010; Powell et al. 2017), this empirical perspective examines prescribed faith-based practices as impersonal mechanisms individuals are forced to exist within, and over which they have no control.

These studies demonstrate how religious rituals facilitate corporeal domination, and map the processes through which it occurs as entirely external. A second strand of sociological literature examines this power—rather than just its effects—as far more embodied structures, by describing how individuals actually participate in its (re)production. These studies establish a direct link between somatic experiences of spiritual practices and their institutional structures, unique to the context of particular faiths. While united in their approach to religious membership as essentially dynamic and *living*, scholars dispute how it is lived; positing different explanations for the paradoxical embodiment of agency and subjectivity that rituals demand. These debates center on the extent to which adherents “freely” (re)construct the same power structures they exist within through their own bodies. The way in which sociological analyses address the question of agency, implicit in the examination of institutional practices, determines their capacity to criticize the power these practices (re)produce. Among these studies, the somatic experience of rituals is most commonly defined as “religious habitus.” This pseudo-embodied approach applies elements of Bourdieusian theory to moralized sensory transformations;

situating rituals as passive processes through which subjects are “unwittingly” (re)shaped by institutional logic, or the *illusio* of the field (Csordas 1997; Krotofil et al. 2021; Winchester 2008). These studies do not adopt Bourdieu’s critical view of habitus as evidence of somatic compliance and submission, where corporeal subjectivity lies “dormant” until “triggered” by external schemas of domination ([1997] 2000). Without operationalizing the more skeptical elements of this framework, analyses of “religious habitus” do not consider individual agency. These interactions are constructed as passive and unidirectional; identifying how the lived body is (re)shaped by rituals, while denying that it also recursively (re)shapes them.

“Opposing” studies acknowledge how individual agency is constrained, but not entirely precluded by religious institutions and their prescribed bodily practices (Mahmood 2012). These analyses employ Foucauldian— rather than Bourdieusian— philosophy to name the practical, corporeal costs of rituals, and to assert their fundamentally coercive function (Schuld 2003). Despite substantive similarities between them, existing studies apply these theoretical frameworks for embodied institutional power in opposition to one another, as logically contradictory. By problematizing the corporeal (re)production of religious power, these studies qualify the embodiment of ritual structures by implying that they preclude agency entirely. From this perspective, adherents are not rendered immobile by the overwhelming mechanisms of total domination that surround them. Instead, they actively transform their own bodies to fit institutional logics of (im)morality. However, current studies define this participation as entirely passive; arguing that members’ corporeal compliance is based on practical knowledge they exercise unintentionally.

A third, smaller [but growing] division of sociological literature examines religious rituals as fully and essentially embodied. These analyses focus on the somatic effects of such

practices, rather than their strategic utility; describing how (im)morality feels, as corporeal sensations. This perspective individualizes the social function of rituals as strengthening adherents' personal faith and spirituality, rather than broader institutional authority. This study of confession builds on existing scholarship in analyzing rich, ethnographic accounts of religious rituals as wholly embodied experiences; examining interviewees' descriptions of how they have been (re)shaped by the Church both theoretically, and viscerally. Prior analyses, however, define similar embodied moral transformations as either psychological, or physical. Some sociologists apply the Durkheimian framework of "emotional energy," to explain how somatic effects of rituals become tangible evidence of individuals' moral transformations (Inbody 2015; Winchester and Pagis 2021). These analyses identify how ephemeral physical reactions to benign or mundane practices are reframed to justify religious beliefs. Over time, these experiences have a legitimizing effect that strengthens individuals' *spiritual* dependence on their faith— and the religious institution to which it belongs (Inbody 2015; Winchester and Pagis 2021). Studies of "religious healing," however, examine a more extreme form of embodied subjectivity that occurs when the long term dependence it entails becomes explicitly *physical*. This research demonstrates how religious rituals are used to treat the physiological affliction of sin, through moral rehabilitation (Csordas 1997; Glassman 2017). Through these "treatments," individuals thereby become entirely reliant on the institution to preserve or restore their spiritual, and actual well-being.

The "Body-Power Synapse": (Re)Producing the Lived Body Through Institutional Practices

This study intervenes in current sociological discussions of embodied rituals by also analyzing confession as a discursive, and practical exercise of the Church's power. Rather than arguing that its social functions are exclusively religious, this analysis situates the phenomenon

of confession in a broader, institutional context. Systematic moralized interactions like these are inherently complex and layered, and cannot be observed directly as homologous or static mechanisms. Instead, they must be examined “in action” through the dynamic lens of individuals’ lived experiences within them. Overarching structures are still traceable through the composite, corporeal ones they (re)produce. Sociologists have long recognized the lived body as the primary target of all power, mapping institutional domination through its tangible effects at the capillary level of the “body-power synapse” (Foucault et al. [1973-4] 2008:40). As a potent site of its application and tool for its (re)production, this empirical subject reveals how such power is (re)constructed in a variety of corporeal forms, specific to both individuals and institutions they exist within. This study follows several others in examining complex power dynamics from the phenomenological perspective of individual embodied experiences; observing confession through interviewees’ somatic sensations of sin and forgiveness.

Existing literature identifies similar phenomena in a wide range of structural contexts, including education, law enforcement, psychiatric counseling, and wellness programs. These studies examine how institutional power systematically (re)shapes subjects’ bodies through strategic policies and mandated practices. While existing analyses all view the lived body through a critical lens, scholars differ in *where* they focus this lens. Similar to studies of religious rituals, sociologists define overarching power structures by either their institutional, or embodied components. Some analyze corporeal transformations by examining the procedural context in which they occur, explaining how bodies are managed and manipulated by discursive or practical instruments. This perspective observes institutional power as external mechanisms of domination, imposed on individuals to (re)produce their uniform subjectivity. Though these structures produce embodied effects, they are essentially *disembodied*, and operate autonomously

within institutions. Guhin analyzes how moral identities are regulated within Christian and Muslim schools; describing how specific prayers and rituals are structured to transform students into corporeally legible subjects (2021). The moralization of individual bodies is not exclusive to religion, however, and is the primary objective of other, secular authorities as well. Garcia identifies this phenomenon in a documentary analysis of how the Cuban government regulates sex workers. Using strategic legislation, the corporeal characteristics of *jineteras*⁵ are operationalized to situate them as an embodied threat to public health, morality, and safety (Garcia 2010). These studies demonstrate how individuals' bodies become representative of their normative value and worth, analyzing prescribed policies and practices as external mechanisms that separate "good" subjects from others who embody challenges to the institution's moral logic.

Another strand of sociological literature examines other similar structures from a phenomenological perspective. These scholars use individuals' lived accounts of institutional practices to explain their embodied effects. Johnson's (2010) analysis is substantively similar to Garcia's (2010) in identifying the systematic (re)construction of an embodied threat to broader social morality. Through ethnographic data, this study describes how public displays of homosexuality are over-policed to define and discipline immorality through its corporeal representations (Johnson 2010). Powell et al employ a similar methodological approach in their observation of live testimony by alleged victims of child sexual abuse (2017). Throughout each trial, defense attorneys and prosecutors strategically reframed childrens' bodily comportment and verbal accounts as evidence of their credibility; defining corporeal indicators of innocence and deception (Powell et al. 2017). Both of these studies delineate institutional power through a distinctly phenomenological lens, and lived accounts of its practical (re)production.

⁵ Garcia uses the informal, derogatory (Spanish) term of "*jineteras*" for prostitutes and sex workers throughout her analysis to emphasize the widespread social impact of the Cuban government's discursive power.

Kurri and Wahlström push these findings even further by relying on individuals' embodied experiences to analyze domestic violence counseling (2001). Through the lens of ethnographic data, this study examines an interpersonal mechanism of institutional power through the intense discursive labor it requires. Using strategic [moral] narratives, psychiatrists help patients (re)construct accounts of past abuse to balance the "weak" helplessness implicit in their victimhood, with the legitimate "strength" of their survivorship (Kurri and Wahlström 2001). This analysis introduces an additional dimension to lived experiences of institutional power. By revealing individuals' active participation in this phenomenon, Kurri and Wahlström provide a *reflexive* account of embodied subjectivity that also accommodates agency (2001). Gerber (2009) and Ignatow (2009) extend this sociological perspective by examining institutional power in its most potent form; as continuous and intentional self-discipline. Both studies of evangelical weight loss programs delineate the systematic conflation of thin and moral bodies; where being overweight signifies both physical gluttony and spiritual neglect. Participants set out to "lose" the weight of sin by losing actual body weight, and hope to achieve moral reformation through bodily recomposition (Gerber 2009; Ignatow 2009). Through intensive corporeal discipline and management, individuals describe how they facilitate their moral transformations through institutional practices that are entirely self-selected and self-directed. In each case, participants are not merely complicit in, but rather practically responsible for the continued regulation and surveillance of their own bodies, without any assistance from, or prompting by external structures.

Empirical Studies of Catholicism: The Church and Its Rituals

While religious rituals and bodily practices within other institutions are the subject of significant sociological interest, Catholicism has yet to be understood from a similar empirical

perspective. Most of this research employs historical or archival methods to analyze Church practices, and does not examine them through the lived body. Some scholarship critiques the Church's institutional power, but largely frames these discussions through the co-emergence of Catholicism and capitalism (Abend 2016; Arruñada 2009). Analyses of specific Catholic rituals are more teleological, tracing their structural evolution alongside the institutional development of the Church (Tentler 1977). These studies situate Catholic practices as a means of amassing vast moral and financial capital that preserve the institution's legitimacy (Arruñada 2009; Tentler 1977). Several sociologists have established their empirical skepticism of the Church's rituals as tools for legitimizing its authority, providing rational accounts of their material— rather than embodied— effects.

These analyses criticize the institutional schemas of Catholic rituals and practices as valuable instruments of organizational enrichment. However, this perspective reveals nothing about how individual members actually experience them. Without this information, the Church's ability to preserve its power through the practical (re)production of embodied subjects is reduced to material motivations. The systematic functions of these rituals are further elided, along with the bodily processes through which they are (re)produced by participants. Bales (2006) and Beste (2011) bridge this empirical gap by examining lived experiences of participating in Catholic communion and [first] confession, respectively. These studies delineate phenomenological explanations of such practices on a micro, interactionist scale, through surveys gauging their attitudinal effects (Bales 2006; Beste 2011). By comparing participants' emotional states and perspectives before and after each ritual, they argue that the Church's sacraments successfully facilitate moral transformations (Bales 2006; Beste 2011).

The present study of confession similarly recognizes how these rituals (re)shape individuals' lived realities, as participants *feel* "changed" by their experiences. However, these data identify such [moral] transformations in confession as essentially corporeal, as interviewees describe them through distinctly tangible, bodily sensations. This lens problematizes confession, and other Catholic rituals, as far more complicated and strategic than purely spiritual practices; analyzing the Church's institutional role in systematically affecting the [embodied] changes individuals experience. This study is the first, and only critical phenomenology of a specific Catholic ritual; striking an empirical balance between members' lived experiences, and the Church's institutional power.

Confession as Structure: (Re)Producing Embodied Agency and Subjectivity

While the sacrament of confession itself has never been studied from a sociological perspective, its essential structural qualities are explored independently through several substantive strands of existing literature. The theoretical and methodological frameworks established by these studies provide a general map of the ritual's dual corporeal, and institutional components. Understanding both of these *schemas* is necessary to explain penitents' unique subjectivity as both embodied [spiritual] experiences, and products of institutional power. In this study, interviewees' accounts of sin and forgiveness as somatic sensations are tangible evidence of the Church's authority, demonstrating how they (re)construct their lived bodies to fit its logic of corporeal (im)morality. These findings build on prior analyses of how religious rituals and analogous secular practices allow institutions to legitimize their broader hierarchies and ideologies through the systematic control of individuals' bodies (Garcia 2010; Glassman 2017; Guhin 2021; Johnson 2010; Mahmood 2012; Powell et al. 2017).

While interviewees' accounts expose how confession also functions this way— to preserve and expand the Church's power— they do not define confession as a wholly external mechanism of complete domination. Rather than describing how the ritual is forced or imposed on them, penitents assert their own dynamic role in ensuring its efficacy, and securing God's forgiveness. By detailing their complex embodied performances of guilt, contrition, and relief, interviewees explain how they actively participate in (re)producing the Church's power; working in concert with the institution to facilitate their moral transformations. Several other studies of similar bodily practices examine these unique power dynamics, in which individuals are entirely complicit in their own corporeal management (Gerber 2009; Ignatow 2009; Kurri and Wahlström 2001). In particular, this analysis extends theories of "religious habitus" that demonstrate how adherents embody institutional moral logics through their entirely unprompted practical compliance with ritual procedures (Csordas 1997; Krotofil et al 2021; Winchester 2008).

Though penitents become complicit in confession, these data do not suggest that this occurs entirely without their knowledge or consent. Contrary to prior theories of "religious habitus" and analogous secular examples, these accounts suggest that penitents' compliance is anything but passive and unintentional. Interviewees describe the ritual through unique discursive frames that expose intentional, nuanced differences in their lived experiences. While their corporeal participation is made institutionally legible through their practical knowledge of confession and the Church, it is not fixed or predetermined. To mitigate perceived past or potential obstacles to God's forgiveness, interviewees continuously adjust how they interact in the ritual, and make sense of the embodied sensations it affects. In finding that the same, institutionally prescribed practice does not reliably (re)produce a uniform embodied subjectivity, this study extends prior literature by examining the role of agency in confession. In this way,

interviewees' diverse lived experiences of the Church's power are not predicted or fully explained by solely analyzing the ritual's structure through the lens of its institutional logic.

Existing studies of "emotional energy" and "religious healing" provide a framework to explain how adherents experience (im)morality inconsistently, as somatic sensations unique to their individual bodies (Csordas 1997; Glassman 2017; Inbody 2015; Winchester and Pagis 2021). This analysis builds on prior findings by describing how interviewees' repeatedly redefine confession's functional purpose as the exclusive means of addressing their unique sensations of sin as corporeal burdens, dirtiness, and ailments. However, just because penitents' experiences of the ritual are not uniform, and partially determined by their individual lived realities, does not mean they are free of institutional influence entirely. This study intervenes in these sociological discussions of religious rituals by analyzing confession as both an embodied experience of individual (im)morality, and the systematic (re)production of the Church's broader power.

While prior studies provide substantive descriptions of the corporeal and institutional schemas of analogous religious and secular practices, none observe them in action, simultaneously. By analyzing these structures separately, rather than how they interact with and affect one another, these perspectives frame confession as an embodied experience of total subjectivity. Whether scholars argue that prescribed bodily practices are wholly external mechanisms of domination, or internal expressions of spirituality, these absolute theories collectively ignore individual agency. This analysis advances such findings by describing not only how confession (re)shapes penitents' bodies, but also how it is reflexively (re)shaped by them (Giddens 1984). Rather than a terminal exercise of the Church's authority, interviewees' accounts demonstrate that the ritual is a continuous process through which they intentionally

integrate the moral logic of the institution, with the corporeal structure of their bodies; becoming indistinguishable from one another as a functional, embodied whole.

In order to explain how the same ritual (re)produces a wide range of somatically oppressive, as well as freeing, cleansing, and healing sensations, this study posits a model of confession that unites prior empirical perspectives of institutional bodily practices. The overarching structure of confession is both systematic, and essentially *living*; as penitents' agency and the Church's power recursively (re)produce and transform each other. This study draws from structuralism's view of human agency and social structures as not only compatible, but also interactive and interdependent (Giddens 1984). This analytical perspective is the subject of significant sociological debate, as the ambiguous concept of social "structure" is interpreted and operationalized in several different, and often contradictory ways. This study depicts a model of confession's embodied systematic structure, that is opposed to the rigidity and impermeability this theoretical framework commonly denotes.

While recognizing that the duality of power structures, like confession, allows agency, structuralist perspectives also imply their overarching stasis (Sewell 1992). However, interviewees' diverse discursive frames for their somatic experiences of sin and forgiveness demonstrate how the ritual is (re)productive of a nonuniform subjectivity— as these corporeal schemas are unique to the individual who embodies them. Similar to "structure," "schema" is an amorphous term formulated to overcome this ontological and temporal dilemma (Sewell 1992). This study operationalizes the concept of "schema" to identify how confession systematically structures interviewees' relationship to the Church through embodied interactions and experiences that are both individualized, and interdependent. Somatic descriptions of (im)morality as feelings external or internal to their lived bodies, reveal interviewees' *corporeal*

schemas. These narratives define the function of confession to free, cleanse, or heal them from sin, and thereby delineate the analogous *institutional* schema of the Church; defining how its moral logic structures the ritual. Through confession, priests and parishioners mutually create these structures, and (re)shape them to fit penitents' lived bodies.

Rather than a closed, positive feedback loop where the same subjectivity is continuously (re)produced, this fluid perspective of confession's structure creates the possibility of broader change. Individuals not only exercise agency by (re)producing the embodied structures that constrain them, but also by (re)forming them in different ways (Sewell 1992). Interviewees' highly personalized frameworks for confession, reveal how the ritual is continuously molded to their specific bodies. Rather than homogenizing penitents' experiences, this study posits a fluid model of confession— and moralized bodily practices in general— as the embodied integration of dual corporeal and institutional schemas; systematically (re)producing individuals' agency and subjectivity through their interactions with the Church.

METHODOLOGY

This study analyzes the structure of confession through the lens of individual experiences; tracing its recursive (re)construction by dual logics of corporeal agency and institutional subjectivity— or schemas. Access to this ritual is restricted to members suitably initiated into the Church through the proper sacramental prerequisites. Confession is predicated on confidentiality, exclusivity, and privacy which wholly precludes direct observation. Instead, I analyze the *phenomenon* of confession as essentially “lived-through,” to reveal its integration of dual corporeal and institutional structures (Merleau-Ponty [1945] 2014). Through over fifty hours of ethnographic interview data, Catholic priests, and lay members and ministers

(“parishioners”) demonstrate— rather than simply define— the ritual through their embodied experiences. Interviewees describe sensations of sin and forgiveness; identifying somatic evidence of their moral transformations. These lived experiences delineate the corporeal schemas which (partially) constitute confession, by mapping the Church’s practical inscription of its moral logic on members. Interviewees’ location of sin as external or internal to their lived bodies, also effectively situates them within the institution. In defining this interdependent relationship, this study’s critical, phenomenological lens depicts a complete view of the ritual as a systematic interaction between corporeal and institutional structures.

Interviewees’ unique, embodied experiences delineate an accurate and objective model of confession, paradoxically enhanced by their highly subjective character. I do not aggregate individual or institutional interpretations of the ritual to trace its homologous interactional structure. Rather, the form and substance of interviews exposed nuanced differences in corporeal schemas that have significant empirical and theoretical implications. Through a memo-based analysis, I explored agents’ discursive and practical attempts to (re)shape their bodies and the institution through confession. This approach is thoroughly phenomenological, as I documented not only what interviewees described, but also *how* they described it. This study is distinguished by its examination of confession, and interviews themselves as equally embodied experiences. Together, these ethnographic data demonstrate the ritual’s fluidity, as a dynamic system in which interviewees exercise their individual agency. This critical use of phenomenology and ethnomethodology throughout data collection and analysis explain why interviewees’ embodied experiences of confession are so diverse; constructing a ritual system capable of reflexive change, as corporeal and institutional schemas continuously (re)mold themselves and each other.

Sampling and Recruitment

I trace the systematic interaction of confession by observing the moment in which its practical logic is discursively (re)produced by those with embodied knowledge of its unique structural qualities. Catholic priests and parishioners who have participated in the ritual, possess this intimate corporeal understanding; articulating direct, sensory accounts of bodily transformation. The moral meanings interviewees ascribe to these experiences are influenced by the institutional authority they are afforded by their role in confession, and position within the Church hierarchy. As “everyday” Catholics who lack any special theological rights and responsibilities, lay members described the ritual from their perspective as penitents. These data demonstrate confession as it is experienced by the widest population within the Church community, and provide embodied evidence of its systematic function. Lay ministers’ perspectives are similarly relevant, though enhanced by their liminal position within the institution. These interviewees possess greater authority than other lay members, but still far less than priests and ordained clergy—entrusted with spiritual direction, pastoral assistance, and other important duties. Lay ministers demonstrate how confession is (re)shaped by individual agency most explicitly, describing the nuanced processes of facilitating others’ embodied participation in the ritual. Finally, as representatives of the institution imbued with the necessary spiritual authority, priests are uniquely situated to explain the duality of confession through their experiences as both penitents *and* confessors. This holistic perspective reflects an embodied dissonance between institutional narratives priests (re)produced, and their own lived experiences of the ritual—delineating their reflexive role as both individual subjects and institutional agents.

This study relies on embodied experiences with confession to inductively map its systematic function. A broad population of Catholics possess practical knowledge relevant to this

analysis, as the Church requires all members to participate in the ritual at least once. Such a large pool of potential participants created a significant methodological challenge of preserving the sample's diversity, while narrowing it to a reasonable scope. However, I do not assert that interviewees represent the Church community as a whole. Rather, I argue that their embodied experiences accurately depict the *phenomenon* of confession, that is widely generalizable. Regardless of the particular agents it involves, or context in which it occurs, the ritual's overarching structure exhibits some uniform qualities across the systematic corporeal performances it prescribes. While differences in interviewees' accounts and discursive (re)production of confession are crucial to this analysis, it would be empirically impossible to obtain a sample that does not represent this practice on a broader scale.

To negotiate the considerable size of this study's population of interest, I employed a sampling method similar to that of Winchester (2008) and Mahmood (2012). Through ethnographic observations of localized communities within larger religious institutions, these scholars argue that subjective embodied experiences remain generalizable; as products of uniform ritual practices. Using an analogous approach in the context of the Church, I limited this study's sample to two midwestern Catholic Dioceses, or district-like groupings of parishes and parochial schools, composed of several mid-size towns and cities. Together, these diverse parish networks provided a combined sample pool of 175 churches, spread throughout 21 counties. I compiled a database of all 175 parishes, some of which are clustered under the leadership of one priest, and randomly selected 20 to contact during the first round of recruitment. Later, I contacted subsequent groups of 5 to 10 parishes, until saturation was reached ($n_{\text{total}} = 32$: $n_{\text{priests}} = 11$, $n_{\text{parishioners}} = 21$). Although I do not formally measure or analyze any demographic variables, interviewees reflect a wide range of ages, gender identities, races, educational backgrounds, and

socioeconomic statuses. Both affluent and economically disadvantaged communities are represented in a variety of geographic contexts, including; large university campuses, rural municipalities, mid-size suburbs, and dense city centers.

Before recruiting individual parishioners, I contacted priests directly, as key gatekeepers to these distinct communities. Using a form email to introduce myself and this study, I inquired about their availability for a brief meeting to discuss their potential participation. Roughly two-thirds of all priests replied; some expressed eager curiosity, while others rejected the opportunity outright. Interested and uninterested priests both discussed their general hesitancy to discuss such a private ritual, and were concerned about violating the Seal of Confession⁶. During our initial meetings, I addressed these questions and discussed the most effective ways to recruit their respective parishioners. Informed by detailed information about each community, I tailored sampling methods and instruments to overcome the demographic characteristics priests identified as potential barriers to reaching certain populations (i.e. mean age, internet access and literacy, language, etc.). Weekly bulletin announcements (Appendix A) were most reliable for recruiting interviewees, supplemented by a Google Form for interest and availability (Appendix B). These instruments provided parishioners with relevant details about this study, and allowed them to contact me individually.

Direct sampling was facilitated by not only priests, but also the secretaries and office personnel at each parish, as unanticipated— but absolutely critical— secondary gatekeepers. These individuals possessed extensive and unique knowledge of parishioners' personal lives and involvement in the Church, often exercising their subtle power by scheduling interviews without

⁶ The Seal of Confession is a theological tradition codified in the Church's canon law. This provision criminalizes priests' disclosure of individuals' sins to others, outside of the confessional. Several priests expressed initial concerns that participating in this study would violate the Seal, which required me to assure them I was not interested in the sins they've heard, but rather how it *felt* to hear them. (See Appendix A, as an example).

my consent! Finally, I encouraged snowball sampling by asking interviewees to share information about this study with other parishioners. This hybrid recruitment model remained fluid, and evolved throughout the data collection process as a combination of adaptable strategies that functioned effectively in a diverse range of parish communities. Through an emphasis on mindful interpersonal interaction, this study's flexible methods circumvented the Church's rigid, and closely guarded institutional hierarchy; recruiting a diverse sample of priests and parishioners with relevant embodied experiences and knowledge of confession.

Interviews

While initial meetings with priests took place over Zoom, the overwhelming majority of interviews occurred at participants' respective home parishes, where they regularly attend Mass and confession. I traveled to each church as necessary, which were scattered throughout the expansive geographic areas of each diocese. Parish secretaries and administrative staff arranged and reserved private auxiliary or multi-purpose rooms for interviews with lay parishioners, generally located within their front offices. These settings provided a comfortable dyadic environment, conducive to both casual and open conversation, and bodily comportment. By contrast, I conducted interviews with priests in their private offices and residences (parish rectories). In these spaces, I was often required to shrink my body into a subordinate, unnatural sitting position across from interviewees; separated by tables, pulpits, and other physical barriers. The few priests that did not sit at their desks chose to turn their chairs away from me—refusing to orient their bodies toward mine, and avoiding direct eye contact. These nonverbal constructions established a palpable [corporeal] power dynamic within each interview. Priests' corporeal orientations within the room symbolized their analogous orientation within the Church, maintaining a discursive and physical distance to (re)assert their institutional authority and

status. To reach saturation, a small number of interviews with both parishioners and priests were conducted over Zoom. The virtual setting did not affect the depth or substance of these data, mirroring the form and content of in-person conversations. However, interview data collected at parishes is uniquely ethnographic, as participants discussed their embodied subjectivities within the institution they are (re)produced by.

Regardless of their physical context, none of these conversations adhered to this study's guide exactly (Appendix C). Interviews ranged in duration from 45 minutes to 2 hours, totaling over 50 hours of data. Wholly participant-driven, this open ended structure resulted in a necessary lack of formal and substantive uniformity. However, I began each interview with a scripted introduction that provided all participants with the same information about myself and the study. This measure of qualitative control preserves the empirical validity of these data by ensuring conversations share a common discursive origin. During this initial interaction, I asked for interviewees' consent to be recorded, and whether they had any lingering concerns or questions about the project, so that I could address them fully, beforehand.

I then asked all participants to begin by telling me about themselves, without any specific direction or prompting. Generally, the interview context was conducive to descriptions of their lives and identities within the Church; foregrounding details about how Catholicism shapes their identities, careers, relationships, and lives more broadly. Interviewees immediately identified the origins of their faith, and discussed being raised Catholic, attending Catholic schools, practicing rituals— and confession— as a family, converting to Catholicism, and several other experiences with the Church. The rest of the interview was derived from this preliminary disclosure, as it provided a natural segue into accounts of their First Reconciliation [or Confession] as children or otherwise “new” Catholics, and the ritual's continued impact on their

lives as a whole. This laid the groundwork for agile and open conversations in which both myself and interviewees felt comfortable discovering important and interesting details, together. I gently probed at relevant information by asking them to “set the scene,” or “tell me more” about the somatic experiences they described. This forensic strategy is objectively phenomenological and ethnographic, as I questioned interviewees using their own language; referencing and repeating phrases verbatim to clarify their meaning. These subsequent inquiries encouraged interviewees to explore and describe their experiences as uniquely corporeal, sensory, and embodied. This significant reflexivity demonstrated how their accounts and understandings of confession are shaped by the Church’s moral logic, without being constrained by the narratives it invokes. Interviewees often had difficulties engaging their bodies at the somatic level, and several acknowledged never discussing the ritual, or the institution, in terms of embodied emotions and sensations. Regardless of the depth with which they embraced this challenge, the flexible and open-ended structure of each interview provided the freedom necessary to experiment with rich descriptions of their lived realities. These data reflect interviewees’ reiterative attempts to articulate subjective internal observations of their embodied experiences with confession, and the Church more generally.

Highly detailed and vulnerable ethnographic accounts referenced visceral sensations of sin and forgiveness that inform this study’s empirical, critical, and structural analysis. Interviews were often the first and only time participants had articulated their experiences with confession, especially in corporeal terms. This unique interpersonal circumstance was precipitated by the ritual’s intensely private nature, and the extemporaneous structure of our conversations. Data collection therefore entailed incredibly delicate interactions that demanded constant corporeal attentiveness. Throughout each interview, I maintained an integrated awareness of my own body

to note and moderate my responses to embodied expressions of intense emotion. Interviewees did not coldly articulate impersonal accounts of confession, but instead fully relieved past somatic experiences through our conversations. The intensity of this connection became most apparent in its dissolution at the end of each interview. I explicitly reassured participants their contributions were valuable and asked if they had any lingering questions, to avoid closing our conversations abruptly. Despite these careful efforts, the final moments of most interviews were plagued by priests' and parishioners' potent anxiety about their high levels of self-disclosure. The individual flexibility of these methods thus facilitated moments of discursive meta-embodiment⁷, during which participants reflexively referenced the embodied sensations throughout the interview itself. Both the form and substance of interviews embrace the body's pervasive salience to interviewees' experiences and discussions of confession, enhancing the ethnographic quality of these data as uniquely tangible and somatic.

Reflexivity

As both subjects and authors of our conversations, interviewees' bodies simultaneously (re)shaped and were (re)shaped by the data collection process. The duality of these interactions produced striking interpersonal dynamics that related directly, and indirectly to confession. My participation in interviews was not passive or impersonal, but rather fully embodied. These experiences addressed and engaged my own corporeality to an equally personal extent as interviewees'. During the scripted introduction to each conversation, I demonstrated appropriate self-disclosure by referencing my background as a lifelong Catholic, and firsthand experience of confession. This information garnered different responses from interviewees in how they decided

⁷ "Meta-embodiment" references discursive acts or experiences of acknowledging, describing, and interpreting (past) embodied experiences that are inherently phenomenological in and of themselves. This adds an additional, somatic layer to these data, and draws attention to how individuals' lived realities are obscured by the Church's normative definitions of their experiences. In these moments, interviewees express discomfort and unfamiliarity with (re)constructing their essentially embodied experiences [for the first time].

to acknowledge and make sense of my identity. Generally, they digested it slowly while our rapport strengthened, until they felt comfortable referencing our shared institutional knowledge. In these moments, interviewees addressed me by name, called attention to my background, and presumed my past experiences in the Church, explicitly. Priests and some lay parishioners tried to discern my faithfulness by reflecting questions back to me, or probing about my personal relationship to the ritual and Catholicism. Specifically, they sought details about my First Reconciliation, the quality of my previous confessions, how often I attended, and when I planned on confessing next. Interviewees expressed their immediate (dis)satisfaction with my answers through blatant concern for my spiritual well being. Priests, in particular, advised and directed me to strengthen my faith in various ways— recommending that I implement certain prayers and regular practices in my life, like confession.

Other interviewees did not evaluate my perspective, or ask for it at all; unilaterally inserting my identity in elaborate discursive illustrations of the ritual and their embodied experiences. Some anecdotes were purely descriptive, and often hypothetical. However, priests' and primarily male parishioners' were distinctly explicit, explaining confession and embodied (im)morality through sexualized examples and metaphors. These pervasive references to lust, pornography, promiscuity, seduction, and sex, were not directed at me personally. Rather, my identity as a young Catholic woman was operationalized as a discursive placeholder for "dangerous" heteronormative female sexuality. In these moments, my body became representative of homogenized gendered experiences in which women and girls are sexualized objects of cis-gender male attention. Interviewees presumed my embodied knowledge of these scenarios to corroborate and frame their assertions of confession's efficacy and necessity. Expressly acknowledging and foregrounding my age, appearance, and gender identity allowed

them to situate the ritual as the only tool for male parishioners to confront the embodied [sexual] threat women and girls pose to their morality.

All of these interactions marked distinct interviewees' distinct shifts from descriptions of their personal beliefs and embodied experiences, to explicit concern for my own faith and commitment to the Church. Such unique conversational dynamics enhance the somatic character of these data, creating an additional opportunity for ethnographic analysis. Interviewees' discursive (re)productions of confession provide critical insight into its systematic cultivation of penitents' embodied subjectivity, equally as rich and valuable as their direct experiences of the ritual. Rather than simply describing this institutional power structure, interviewees demonstrate it phenomenologically, through their supplemental reliance on my own lived body to define confession in terms of their corporeal observations.

Analysis

All interviews are transcribed in full, however, this study primarily relied on memo-based thematic analysis. This approach involved note-taking, partial transcription, and qualitative coding of at three levels; individual cases, analytical groups, and the whole dataset. After a preliminary review of these data, I organized interviews in a "Data Analysis Spreadsheet" by their coded identifiers, setting, analogies used for confession, depth of embodied description, notable interactions, and unique content. This made critical characteristics of each interview easily accessible throughout the memo writing process. The Spreadsheet also organized conceptualizations of key concepts, complete with indices tracking the interviews in which priests and parishioners discussed them.

At the first level of analysis, I wrote memos summarizing individual cases ("summary memos"), following a fixed template (Appendix D). Summary memos list interviews' coded

identification numbers, analytical group, and informally measured demographic characteristics to better contextualize each case. Most importantly, these memos contain an “Interview Story” composed of three subsections; (1) Background and Initial Interactions, (2) Summary, and (3) Closing Interactions. Throughout each of these, I describe both the substantive content, and embodied experience of each interview— creating a complete ethnographic record of additional observations that enriches discursive data. The extensive duration and semi-structured form of interviews precluded immediate transcription. As the first level of analysis, summary memos connected participants’ often disparate embodied accounts, isolating critical disclosures from more tangential (re)explanations of Church doctrine. This guarded against homogenization, delineating *individualized* corporeal schemas that reflect interviewees’ nuanced somatic experiences of sin and forgiveness. Summary memos thus provided objective access to these data, from which I then extracted key concepts and excerpts, subsequently recorded on the Data Analysis Spreadsheet.

After completing all summary memos, I organized individual cases into two analytical groups; priests and lay parishioners. In this second stage of analysis, I wrote memos (“analytical group memos”) for each group; identifying their type (priests/parishioners), group conceptualization and scope, individual group members, relevant demographic details, an executive summary of interview content and experiences, notes on intra- and inter-group differences, and a list of key concepts and excerpts (Appendix E). As institutional actors with the most insular knowledge of confession and Church practices, priests provided embodied personal accounts and valuable doctrinal explanations. The content of these interviews and limited sample size ($n_{\text{priests}} = 11$), effectively segmented priests into their own analytical category. Though individuals’ experiences varied greatly, I combined remaining interviewees in a second group of

lay parishioners ($n_{\text{parishioners}} = 21$). This condensed category exposed themes across the entire dataset, demarcating individuals' corporeal schemas into two, fluid sub-categories; moral externalists, and moral internalists. This flexible typology constructs a permeable distinction between the discursive frames interviewees employ to describe their embodied experiences. Moral externalists were identified through their conceptualizations of sin as burdens, weight, dirt, and uncleanness as immorality outwardly imposed on [and thus removable from] their lived bodies. By contrast, moral internalists were identified through their conceptualizations of sin as theoretical and physiological disease, injury, or illness to define immorality as an integrated, corporeal extension of their lived bodies. As I later note in the discussion of this study's results, this distinction is not based on surface-level, semantic analysis of participants' moralized language. Rather, embodied descriptions of sin as tangible somatic sensations map differences in interviewees' agentic (re)production of confession—constructing individual and institutional schemas using frames recursively shaped by the systematic (ritual) interaction between them.

In a final round of memos (“thematic memos”), I critically examined these typologies and other key thematic strands throughout the dataset as a whole. Through this tertiary analysis, I identified specific areas of focus to integrate this study's dually ethnographic data; tracing the structural origins and qualities revealed by individuals' embodied experiences of both confession, and interviews themselves. Each thematic memo lists relevant cases, an executive summary of analogous sub-themes, as well as key concepts and excerpts (Appendix F). Throughout this stage of analysis, I completed thematic memos as needed to address emergent patterns and inconsistencies throughout the dataset. Areas of focus include; priests' (dis)embodied agency, cultural dynamics within the Church, faith formation during childhood,

sexualized moral metaphors, and confession's performative nature. This study's primary findings are structured by a combination of both these, and analytical group memos. Each stage of data analysis exposed corporeal and institutional schemas as inherently interdependent structures, co-constitutive of one another. Nuanced differences in embodied accounts provide a complete view of confession; mapping the systematic and reflexive (re)production of individual lived realities throughout the ritual. These phenomenological methods present these objective ethnographic data as embodied evidence of confession's systematic function and structure.

RESULTS

This project examines ethnographic data collected through 31 semi-structured interviews⁸ with 11 Catholic priests, and 21 lay parishioners to understand (1) how they experience confession, (2) how confession functions in practice, and (3) how confession structures their relationship with the Church. Throughout these extensive open-ended conversations, interviewees demonstrate that the ritual is essentially embodied by describing how sinfulness and forgiveness feel as somatic sensations. Confession transforms them both morally, and corporeally, as the Church's logic of sin is grafted onto their lived bodies and becomes a tangible part of them. Priests and parishioners explain how the interaction requires complex and strategic performances from both individual, and institutional perspectives; detailing the roles of penitents and confessors, simultaneously. Interviewees describe their participation in confession, and its effects through personalized discursive frames, uniquely fitted to their lived bodies. These diverse and nuanced accounts reveal that they experience the same ritual, in vastly different ways— as both somatically oppressive, and freeing, cleansing, or even physiologically healing. In

⁸ Only 31 interviews were conducted with 32 total participants, because parishioners Sarah and Matt were interviewed together, as a married couple.

contrast to prior empirical analyses of similar [religious] bodily practices, these data do not depict confession as terminally productive of penitents' uniform subjectivity. Rather, interviewees' distinct (re)constructions of the ritual suggest they also exercise significant agency in working with the Church to facilitate their embodied moral transformations. By describing both how confession uniquely (re)shapes and is (re)shaped by their individual bodies, interviewees posit a more dynamic model of its dual corporeal and institutional structure. This study argues that the ritual facilitates an interdependent, and recursive relationship between penitents and the Church, and thus ensures their *mutual* survival.

Understanding the “Whole Being” in Confession: Penitents’ Embodied Experiences

As a sacrament in the Catholic Church and faith, confession is a sacred ritual and exclusive opportunity to commune with God. The experience is elevated above the mundane practices of everyday life, as a moment of supernatural encounter with the divine. Both priests and parishioners acknowledge the power of confession, and express great reverence for the profound experience of God's forgiveness. Some interviewees argued that the ritual's intensity resists any rational articulation, and found it difficult or altogether impossible to adequately describe its effects. Others managed to define the ritual in more concrete terms, while preserving its “otherworldliness” as incomparable to normal phenomena. Regardless of whether interviewees acknowledge their ability to do so, all of them describe confession as a unique experience with both spiritual and ontological utility. The ritual is instrumental in defining the Catholic identity, and differentiates the Church— and its members— from other religious organizations. For Father Luke, the unique power to hear confessions is precisely what attracted him to the priesthood. The ritual's dynamic provides him with exclusive access to otherwise

privileged information, distinguishing his elevated authority and role within both the institution, and “human existence” more broadly.

*It's [confession is] one of those the most priestly things about being a priest...there's nothing an ounce like it... **it feels like you're in a different world** because it is so different. You don't get that experience in any other part of human existence. - Father Luke, priest of 4 months*

By all accounts of the Church, confession is an *out of body* experience that transcends the anthropomorphic and “human” elements of the social world. However, this narrative is contradicted by penitents’ lived realities. For these interviewees, confession is fundamentally *embodied*. Their preparation for, participation in, and perception of the ritual are all centered on how well they look, feel, and function. Instead of a supernatural encounter, confession [and the Church] demands intensive effort and transformation that is essentially corporeal.

Interviewees describe the ritual through the language of their bodies, delineating its extensive emotional, psychological, physical, and otherwise somatic effects. Rather than discerning its efficacy in spiritual terms, they look inward for sensory evidence of their (im)morality. Sin and forgiveness are actual feelings and tangible indicators of penitents’ moral condition. Interviewees rely on both their intellectual, and practical knowledge to describe the ritual as a wholly embodied experience that involves penitents’ “whole being.” Amanda, who rarely goes longer than a week without confession, explains that it transforms “every part” of her.

*... **it affects every part of me**, you know, it's not just like a spiritual– it's just **my whole being**. - Amanda, lay parishioner*

The effects of confession are not exclusively moral, but instead are total– impacting the spiritual, emotional, intellectual, and physical being as an integrated whole. For Matt, the holistic nature of this transformation is evidence of the ritual’s “genius” logic and structure.

*... this is part of why I see the genius of reconciliation... because it heals you as a person. It's not just spiritually, mentally, psychologically, physically, whatever... but **it heals the total person.** - Matt, lay parishioner*

Confession (re)produces real sensations of sin and forgiveness that affect the “total person,” by addressing penitents’ moral and physiological well being. The ritual thus becomes a necessary practice in their lives; essential to strengthen not only their faith, but also their actual bodies. Rather than a purely spiritual experience, interviewees are cognizant and even appreciative of its corporeal impacts. The institution’s moral logic of sin is structurally integrated with their whole, lived bodies through the ritual. In this way, (im)morality is naturalized as embodied feelings and knowledge that shape interviewees’ understanding of confession, themselves, and the Church.

Penitents’ extreme dependence on the ritual is a striking analytical conclusion on its own. However, a more critical lens reveals both how and why it is practically (re)produced. Interviewees’ conceptualizations and experiences of embodied (im)morality, challenge a unidirectional construction of confession as only beneficial to penitents. Instead, these data establish confession as symbiotically necessary for the *mutual* survival of individuals, and the institution. For both penitents and the Church, the ritual functions as an effective means of creating, increasing, and maintaining their respective worth and value. Individually, interviewees describe confession as an opportunity to identify, and take accountability for their sins. Functionally, however, confession establishes penitents’ own bodies as credible evidence of their inherent (im)morality. The internalization of sin thus cements their perpetual dependence on the ritual, and disguises the institution’s role in its constant (re)production.

These data map how penitents are (re)inscribed with the Church’s moral logic through confession, by tracing where they feel sin and forgiveness on or within their lived bodies. However, interviewees’ highly individualized descriptions reveal the many different ways in

which they experience the same ritual. Despite the systematic bodily practices prescribed by the Church, these data suggest that confession may exhibit a wide range of functional purposes and structural qualities at once. The institution extends penitents considerable interpretive liberty in how they define and feel their embodied (im)morality, and transformations facilitated by the ritual. Interviewees describe penitents' actions, priests' duties, sin, forgiveness, and confession itself through corporeal narratives of freedom/unburdening, cleanliness/cleansing, theoretical health/sickness, and actual health/sickness. These accounts are critically distinguished by where they orient sin in relation to the lived body, as either external or internal. This prepositional distinction extends far beyond language, and is not superficially discursive. Rather, it reflects how confession encourages and facilitates a distinctive turn inward. Interviewees who locate sin on their bodies, as separate and removable burdens, weights, dirt, and marks, are *moral externalists*. By contrast, *moral internalists* locate sin within their bodies as an integrated part of their corporeal being; manifesting as physiological afflictions, disabilities, and illnesses. The more deeply penitents embody sin, the harder it becomes for them to disembody. Increasingly unable to distinguish between these individual and institutional structures, interviewees experience confession as corporeal labor that continuously grows more demanding. Moral externalists' and internalists' efforts to separate themselves from sin [and the Church] gradually become more complex, difficult, and precarious; until it is impossible to do so altogether.

Interviewees thereby delineate a clear continuum of their embodied (im)morality through the use of unique discursive frames to describe their somatic experiences of sin, forgiveness, and confession. These data resist rigid typologies, and are instead linked together by fluid and interdependent relationships. Sin is not exclusively identified as either external or internal to the lived body, and is often located through combinations of these amorphous narrative structures.

Interviewees freely transgress the permeable discursive boundaries separating their respective stages of embodied moral subjectivity. The intensity of sin as a somatic sensation, and the corporeal effort required for relief, reflect the degree to which the Church's moral logic is enmeshed with interviewees' own corporeal logic, and (re)structures their lived realities. Thus, the extent to which sin is internalized and fully embodied demonstrates the extent to which the Church is also. For interviewees— primarily moral internalists— who are unable to cure the physiological ailment of immorality from their bodies, to sin is to exist, and to exist is to sin. These accounts provide the most potent, tangible evidence of the Church's power in confession, as interviewees explain the only way to inhabit the world is to be *inhabited* by the institution.

Moral Externalists

Moral externalists locate sin as immoral foreign objects or forces outwardly imposed *on* their lived bodies. Through the first and most common framework, interviewees compare sin to heavy burdens, weights, or restraints that inhibit and limit the body's physical capacity and full range of motion. This oppressive presence is uniquely shaped through interviewees' (re)constructions of sin as burdens that become progressively heavier. Confession is a corporeal effort to remove these from penitents' shoulders, backs, and bodies in general. Forgiveness is an analogous somatic experience of the lightness and relief that comes from setting down, or shirking off the physical weight of sin. Stanley, a military veteran who became Catholic as an adult, describes this exactly, comparing the bodily sensation of confession to taking off a heavy backpack.

*... most times, you just come out of the confession, and **you just feel lighter**. You just feel better, and just feel like **the weight of sin is just off you**... **If you're carrying something heavy like a backpack, and then you let it down, that's kind of what confession** sometimes, most of the time, feels like. - Stanley, lay parishioner*

Father Luke goes even further, estimating the vague heaviness Stanley describes with greater specificity. In its absence after confession, he deduces that sin weighs roughly “50 pounds.”

*You just feel like there's **a physical weight lifted off of you** ... that's— you feel attached **to yourself**. That's **dragging you down** ... that's lifted ... You just feel **50 pounds lighter**.*
- Father Luke, priest of 4 months

For other interviewees, the burden of sin exceeds the capacity of any “backpack,” and its heaviness cannot be quantified by any rational metric. The feeling of forgiveness is thus also intensified, as profound relief from an unimaginably oppressive force. Matt experiences the “tangible” weight of sin in its heaviest form, as “the weight of the world” on his shoulders.

*I couldn't tell you how many times I have left the confessional just feeling like **the weight of the world is off my shoulders** ... **you just feel lighter than air**, because you know it's gone. That weight's been lifted ... it has been about **as close to a physical sensation as you can imagine**. That experience of **having that weight lifted, is tangible**.* - Matt, lay parishioner

Interviewees' embodied experiences of sin as burdens and weights with specific structural qualities, reflect the evolution of sins' bodily effects. The heaviness or lightness of (im)morality—which increases without limit—reflects the depth to which interviewees embody the Church's moral logic. Throughout the gradual intensification of its somatic effects, interviewees situate confession as an increasingly necessary, and *corporeally* demanding practice; where detaching sin from their bodies is analogous to either simply removing a backpack, or the entire world from their shoulders.

Interviewees also conceptualize sin as external constraints that pose slightly different barriers to their moral progress. These include specific comparisons to chains and weights attached to penitents' wrists or ankles that prevent interviewees from moving normally, and as they desire—affixed to their bodies and “dragging” them down. Confession removes their physical restraints, and forgiveness is analogous to free, unbounded action. Maria, a lifelong

Catholic, experiences sin as “balls and chains” that she is eager to “unlock” through the ritual. Forgiveness allows her to “move forward,” freeing her from the oppressive weights that anchor her in a static, (im)moral location.

*It's like having balls and chains, for me. **It's just walking in with balls and chains, and the moment I'm absolved, it's unlocked,** and I need to book it out of there before those chains get back on, you know? Like that's not going to happen again... and the moment that that is resolved, **that knowledge and desire to move forward— it's just a freedom feeling.** - Maria, lay parishioner*

Father Mark describes a similar “freedom feeling” by comparing the corporeal imminence of sin, to specific past experiences of being unable to move in the way he wanted. As a former professional triathlete, he described the ritual through the framework of a race. Before confession, Father Mark feels like he did during his least favorite segment of each competition—the run. Sin depletes and exhausts him in the same way as sprinting the final 10 kilometer stretch. Forgiveness provides him with the energy necessary to push through to the finish, accelerating his sluggish [immoral] pace and running “free,” “like a kid.”

*There's freedom like, **“I have been freed. I've been released.”** You know, it's like, in triathlons, the run for me was always the hardest, you know, because I'd give it all on the bike. And I always joke when I'm running to pass the time, like, **‘I'm dragging cinder blocks, I'm dragging cinder blocks, I'm dragging cinder blocks,’ because it feels like I'm running so slow— it's like, I wish someone would cut the cinder blocks so I wouldn't feel this way, so I could be free and so I could run— fully enter into my humanity, right?... so that's part of confession as well, right, it's like, “Hey man [imitates snipping sound] those cinder blocks— go, run! Have fun! You know?”** And you'll run out into the field like a kid playing with their friends— **it's just like you're free—** you ever watch kids run and play? Not a care in the world, man. Not a care in the world. - Father Mark, priest of 3 years*

Father Mark describes the somatic constraint of sin by relating it to familiar sensations he has experienced in the past. His descriptions of these feelings reflect a deeper embodiment and proto-internalization of sin, as still external, but corporeally familiar to his lived body. Father

Mark's (re)constructions of sin and forgiveness are uniquely personal and specific; using his *muscle memory* of the ritual's logic to articulate his experiences.

Interviewees' descriptions of confession as freeing or liberating themselves from oppressive weights and tight restraints, delineate a clear progression of their embodied (im)morality. Despite several analytically significant nuances, moral externalists are united in their view of confession as a singular, one-time act of shedding immorality. While these descriptions are still embodied and reference "tangible" experiences of heaviness, weight, and constrained movement, sin is ultimately detachable from penitents' bodies. The demands and intensity of this corporeal maintenance and labor is shaped by interviewees' individual experiences, identities, and moral development within the Church. By defining forgiveness as "freedom" and "liberation," interviewees are able to completely sever themselves from the burden of sinfulness imposed *on* them as an external force or object.

The second most common frame moral externalists invoke, compares (im)morality to (un)cleanliness. These interviewees closely approach the boundary separating them from moral internalists, as sin is not quite part of, but organically grafted onto their lived bodies. As a result, the corporeal labor required to separate themselves from immorality becomes more complex; equivalent to cleaning, maintenance, and purification, of which the body is the subject, agent, or both. Some interviewees experience confession as cleansing of their lived bodies directly, like using hand sanitizer, and bathing or washing themselves. Others compare the ritual to symbolically cleaning, "tidying," and organizing physical objects and spaces, representative of their lived bodies. Exactly what interviewees identify confession as cleansing, determines how embodied these efforts, and sin, become; requiring different corporeal processes of instant and complete removal, or long term and precarious *extraction*. Moral externalists are stratified by

these distinctions, which determine how deeply they link (im)morality to [the surface of] their lived bodies. Descriptions of “cleaning” as more complex and physically taxing, reflect a more complete embodiment of sin as nearly impossible to fully distinguish and extricate from their own corporeality.

While descriptions of heavy burdens and weights externalize sin far more explicitly than those of dirt, stains, and “scum,” sin is similarly located *on* penitens’ lived bodies. (Im)morality is not [yet] a fully integrated extension of interviewees’ corporeal structure, as forgiveness allows them to feel completely “clean.” Phil articulates this sensation exactly, describing a powerful confession as the impetus for his recovery from a long term drug and alcohol addiction. Through the ritual, he had been “washed” from the “dirt” of his past sins.

*The freedom from sin— the knowing that I was finally... clean. I don't know what— **I just felt clean.** I just felt like **all that dirt of sin had been washed from me...** - Phil, lay parishioner*

Amanda describes a similar feeling through a slightly different lens; identifying a somatic similarity between her experience of *moral* cleanliness, and the *physical* cleanliness of her new, perfectly “white” shoes.

*I went to confession, and I remember when I left, I was wearing white sneakers. When I left, the priest just looked at me with a smile and he was like, “**You're clean, just like your shoes.**” **Because my— I had really white sneakers...** And I was like, “**Yeah. That's how I feel!**” - Amanda, lay parishioner*

Both of these descriptions situate confession as an embodied, but relatively straightforward “cleansing.” These parishioners only reference the corporeal labor of moral transformation in passing, and instead focus on its functional certainty in producing a definitive cleanliness. Jeremy, who credits the sacrament with his recovery from a debilitating pornography addiction, expresses a more instrumentalist perspective of the ritual through this frame. By comparing

confession to using hand sanitizer, or— more accurately— to taking a bath, Jeremy defines the specific forms of bodily effort it requires. Descriptions of “killing” bacteria and “scraping” off “scum,” situate the embodied labor of removing sin as intense and almost violent.

*... you are clean of everything that you've done... It [confession] is a **hand sanitizer**... Not even that— it's not even a hand sanitizer. It's a **bath**. Right hand sanitizer— not really good for you... It's killing all the good stuff too... But it is a bath, it is **scraping off the scum**, leaving what is good... - Jeremy, lay parishioner*

This construction of the ritual denotes extreme, intentional effort required to address the organic bond between the body and (im)morality. As Jeremy explains, far more demanding labor than “washing” is required to truly cleanse penitents. Rather, a full moral transformation is only possible through aggressive corporeal interventions to separate sin from the “good” parts of them. Though bodily cleansing takes different forms, all of these moral externalists generally view confession as an isolated event. Regardless of its intensity, this embodied labor is temporary and limited in scope. Like setting down a backpack or unlocking chains, these interviewees describe sin as clearly distinct and entirely separate from their lived bodies. Through its definitive “cleansing,” confession produces individuals who feel completely forgiven, moral, and “clean” after a brief bath or shower.

However, other interviewees employ this frame to describe the ritual as a far more complicated and embodied process. They articulate lingering feelings of sinfulness as dirt and other unclean marks that are stubbornly affixed to the surface of their lived bodies. These accounts suggest penitents’ immorality is so deeply embodied that it may be impossible— or at least a lifelong struggle— to cleanly distinguish and remove through confession. As a result, the labor demanded by the ritual is not only intense, but also arduous and complex, like “scrubbing,” and “tidying.” The prolonged and rigorous process of moral transformation, means it can never be truly complete; causing interviewees to wonder if they are completely “clean” and forgiven.

Elaine, a cradle Catholic⁹, recalled experiencing this profound anxiety as a child. She describes still being able to see— and feel— the mark of sin on her body, like the edges of a stain she couldn't fully “scrub out.”

*But I remember thinking, too, “What if I forgot something?” you know? ... “Was I really absolved?” It is almost like **a feeling of never being able to feel like you're fully... clean**... Like there was always— like if you— if I had a mental image of like, there's always like— you scrub **a stain out**, but sometimes you can still see the edges of the stain, you know... like **“I can never get clean...”** - Elaine, lay minister*

As Elaine articulates, confession is not always functionally reliable. The somatic sensation of sin lingers as tangible, but nearly imperceptible uncleanliness on the body. As a result, the ritual is structurally incomparable to instantaneous cleansing like baths, showers, and washing. Instead, sin is a dirty mark on penitents' bodies that may never come out completely, and “stains” them with lasting immorality. Continued “scrubbing” is necessary to address these, and any other dirt of sins penitents might have failed to confess. Other interviewees articulate perpetual concern for the completeness of their moral transformations by delineating confession as similar processes that emphasize the ritual's necessarily complex, embodied labor. Maria, who attends confession weekly, describes this effort by contrasting the corporeal scrupulosity entailed by “tidying” and “keeping it [the body] clean.”

***It's the difference between tidying, and keeping things clean.** And prepared, right? **When you just tidy, you make it look clean.** But, when you're cleaning, you prevent— **when you keep things clean, you prevent any uncleanliness.** When you just tidy, you're putting things away and wiping the counter. But, you could walk in and be like, “What is that odor?” and you can't figure out what it is. And you realize it's the dishwasher, you know what I mean? But, if your spiritual routine was not to just keep things tidy, but to keep things clean, in preparation— like, if you had a guest, you'd clean your house, right? You'd be like, okay, you don't want them to see what's on the baseboards, underneath the sink. Okay. You're really, really anal about that. Right. What if Christ was coming into your home? You expected Him, He said He was coming. And He was like, “I'm not going*

⁹ Several interviewees identified themselves as “cradle Catholics” to reference having been raised in the Church, by a Catholic family, who sent them to Catholic schools.

*to have a schedule, I'm just going to be there. I just want you to know that I'm going to arrive." **Wouldn't you keep it clean? Or would you just tidy?** I think a big mindset is, "I'm just going to keep it clean— it's just going to look clean," you know?... but keeping things clean and prepared is something very, very different. - Maria, lay parishioner*

By looking for hidden or lingering immorality on the “baseboards” and “underneath the sink,” Maria emphasizes the importance of being thorough in confession. Just as with her home, she explains how sin can only be removed from penitents’ bodies through more intensive “cleaning,” as opposed to superficial “tidying” which only disguises their immorality by making them “look clean.” Elizabeth demonstrates this complex corporeal effort, through a highly personalized example. Specifically, she likens the moral cleansing of confession to the systematic cleaning of her car. Rather than behind dirty baseboards and kitchen appliances, Elizabeth expresses pervasive anxiety about evidence of her (im)morality hiding in the backseat; a nagging feeling that persisted even while she was hospitalized, physically unable to confess [or sin] for months on end. Like stray french fries, she is deeply concerned there may be unconfessed or unforgiven sins “tucked into the cushion,” that prevent her from being completely “clean” and moral.

*... [you can] compare confession to **the cleaning out of your car**... When you get a new car or something, your habit is, “Okay, I’m done with this. Throw it in the backseat.” And... **the backseat is like you, and you’re compared to the car, and that’s where you shove all that bad stuff, is back there. And that’s when you go to confession, it’s like cleaning out that backseat, and really getting it clean**... You pick up all the garbage in a garbage bag. Pick up all of the miscellaneous stuff in a bag that you can go through later... You’re always looking behind you. You’re always like, “is it clean?”... You make sure that everything’s vacuumed because **there might be some grains of sand and stuff in places you don’t want them to be... fries tucked into the cushion**... so you’re like, cleaning up, but then when the car is clean, you’re like, “Ahh.” It’s like a breath of fresh air. You’re like, “I can take on the world now.” So, when you go to confession, it’s kind of the same way... - Elizabeth, lay parishioner*

This detailed and exhaustive cleaning, reflects a much deeper embodiment of (im)morality. As they equate confession to more demanding and strenuous bodily labor, sin becomes

progressively harder to extricate from interviewees through its stronger corporeal roots. Critically, this perspective challenges the Church's objectivist accounts of the ritual as unconditionally effective, regardless of the circumstances, priests, or penitents it involves. Instead, these interviewees' experiences demonstrate that, like sinfulness, the feeling of forgiveness is entirely embodied and subjective; complicating the ritual, and the moral logic it (re)produces, as significantly precarious. This trend continues throughout the data, and interviewees describe increasingly more difficult and embodied efforts to separate themselves from sin, until forgiveness becomes impossible altogether.

Moral externalists share at least three defining characteristics that differentiate them from other interviewees. First, they locate sin outside their lived bodies, as external burdens, constraints, dirt, or stains that are imposed *on* them. Second, these interviewees entertain confession's efficacy in extricating sin from their bodies through their experiences of forgiveness as [mostly] absolute freedom and cleanliness. Third, these conditions logically entail that sin and immorality— while still embodied— is plausibly severable from penitents through their regular confession, and continued dependence on the Church.

Moral Internalists

Unlike moral externalists, other interviewees articulated a far more internal conceptualization of sinfulness. Rather than locating evidence of (im)morality on their lived bodies, moral internalists look even deeper; experiencing and identifying sin *within* their lived bodies. These frames reflect interviewees' extreme and complete embodiment of subjectivity, as the Church's constructed (im)morality becomes a tangible part of them. Rather than inhibiting penitents' movement, or diminishing their appearance, sin is internalized as an explicitly corporeal ailment, disability, or disorder that threatens their physiological well being. Immorality

is both theoretically compared to, and *viscerally* experienced as pain, sickness, and other bodily afflictions. Confession is the antidote, procedure, or treatment through which penitents are “healed” or “cured” of their sinful conditions.

The first frame employed by these interviewees defines sin in terms of theoretical sickness and health. The embodied experience and sensation of (im)morality is *likened* to emotional, psychological, and physical illness or wellness. Sin is internalized as an ailment or disease that inhibits normal bodily functions. Forgiveness heals, rehabilitates and strengthens penitents’ bodies to guard against (im)moral pain and sickness. From this perspective, confession is commonly understood as a healthy habit that prevents the onset of moral ailment, disability, or generalized dysfunction. These interviewees compare the ritual to a variety of treatments and wellness practices aimed at healing, strengthening, and rehabilitating their lived bodies. Father Paul, who also attends confession frequently as a penitent, explains confession as the moral “medicine” he ingests to relieve the “symptoms” of sin.

*It's rare that I don't want to [go to confession], because, like, I know that there's some **spiritual medicine** coming my way... If you have a really bad cold, and you take medicine, like, **the symptoms get better**, right? Like, it's— **you may not be perfect, right, but you have some relief**, right? -Father Paul, priest of 6 years*

By comparing immorality to a “really bad cold,” Father Paul implies confession should be taken *as needed*, to address the periodic— and inevitable— ailment of sin. However, other interviewees argued this moral and corporeal intervention should be repeated on a more regular basis. Instead of a means to relieve their symptoms of immorality, these interviewees describe confession as a preventative wellness practice. The ritual does not resolve immediate, and temporary afflictions of sin, but rather ensures the body’s proper functioning, long term. Father Luke describes confession as a “nutritional experience” that feeds and fortifies him on a regular basis— not just when he is starved by sin.

*... it made it easier to do a regular confession where you're not going every time you think you need confession, but just make it a regular part of your spiritual habits— **it's a nutritional experience** for your spiritual life to have a **regular habit**... **Feeding your soul**. - Father Luke, priest of 4 months*

Father Paul expresses a similar view of the continuous effort and bodily attention confession requires. Rather than an explicitly preventative measure that strengthens individuals against possible sin, he situates the ritual as a means of shedding sin that is already embodied. In this frame, the practice requires extensive bodily discipline to “lose” the *body weight* of sin. Penitents must choose the healthier option of confession over immediate indulgences in immorality to “notice a big difference” long term.

*I am confident that if you come to confession regularly, you will notice a big difference.” **It's like weight loss. Look in the mirror every day**, you may not notice a difference, but after a couple of years you'd be like, “Holy cow. This is a little different.” - Father Paul, priest of 6 years*

Comparisons to both nutrition and weight loss emphasize the repeated necessity of confession, as a preventative means of preserving the body’s moral appearance and feeling. However, other interviewees express far more embodied frames for the ritual, describing how confession preserves their capacities for action and movement— which are hypothetically inhibited by sin. While this viewpoint was common among interviewees, Linda and Sarah, both cradle Catholics who still attend confession regularly as adults, articulated particularly thorough comparisons to physical exercise that makes their bodies feel “better” and “stronger”; despite dreading the strenuous and unpleasant corporeal exertion it requires.

*Now I try to go a little more often. And you know, you always feel better after you leave. **It's like exercising**, you know. You're never like, “Oh darn, I wish I wouldn't have exercised today.” Like, you have to force yourself and you're like, “**No, I know I'll feel better after I do it**,” you know. That's like confession, you know— I don't want to do it, but once I go, **I always feel better afterwards... like relief**. - Linda, lay parishioner*

***Just like when you're working out physically.** You're like, "Oh, I need to concentrate on this, improve this." Or if I have an injury, you're supposed to do **physical therapy** to improve that injury, right? **To heal that injury...** it can either be a **detriment** and let it **fester**, or you can let it **heal** and it makes you **stronger**.* - Sarah, lay parishioner

These accounts situate confession as necessary and routine— albeit uncomfortable— bodily maintenance. This moral “exercise” not only ensures that penitents feel better, but also that they can *do* more. Rather than the body’s physical appearance or internal well being, these accounts express implicit concern for how the inevitable “injury” of sin might inhibit their abilities and movement. In this way, the regular and intense moral workout confession provides, ensures individuals are “strong” enough to be fully functioning members of the Church.

This framework explicitly acknowledges that confession is a means of actively changing and (re)constructing penitents’ lived bodies. Interviewees who unburden or cleanse themselves through the ritual only acknowledge how it affects surface-level appearances. However, these penitents demonstrate how their moral transformations involve more substantial changes to bodily compositions and functions. Whether confession preserves, restores, or rehabilitates interviewees, they conceptualize sin as an internal affliction and defect of the lived body. In this way, their (im)morality becomes even more inextricable and intrinsic. Unlike moral externalists, these interviewees cannot sever themselves from sinfulness, which is not only a somatic extension, but an integrated (dis)functional part of their whole being. These descriptions further locate penitents’ bodies as the site for continued moral (re)formation through confession, as they experience and understand sinfulness as an inherent condition analogous to their corporeal health and well being.

Other interviewees do not merely compare or liken sinfulness to pain and sickness, but experience it *viscerally*. The frame that reflects the most extreme, and deeply embodied conceptualization of confession, describes tangible experiences of healing through the ritual;

where (im)morality is physiological. Sinfulness causes or constitutes a legitimate medical condition that literally afflicts them, and inhibits normal bodily functions. The embodied experience of sin is one of bodily ailment and disability, which forgiveness effectively cures or treats. These moral internalists believe their lives have actually been saved, and their bodies have actually been healed through confession. Some interviewees, like Sarah, emphasize a logical connection between the psychological benefits of the ritual, and their improved physical well being. Confession alleviates guilt as the cause of mental anguish and stress that “breaks” or “weakens” the physical body over time.

It is healing your wounds. It is healing wounds emotionally, and mentally, and it improves your physical health as well, right?... people go, “Oh, I’ve screwed up, but I have hope that I can get better—” that’s really significant... You think of guilt, it adds stress, right? So, we know that there is a correlation between your mental health, and your physical health. Those two feed off of each other... they [powerful adversaries] go after the mind first because the mind is easier to break than the human body. You can physically break the human body, it will heal. - Sarah, lay parishioner

Though she discursively separates the mind and body, Sarah identifies the psychological stress of sin, and its analogous physical effects. For her, and several other interviewees, the embodied “healing” of confession is experienced as legitimate psychological relief from guilt and anxiety. Others, however, report even more profound, and miraculous experiences of *physical* healing. For instance, Amanda struggled with a chronic, debilitating illness that made it difficult for her to walk, stand, and move normally throughout most of her adult life. After decades of failed treatments, procedures, and other medical interventions, she was convinced that her condition was incurable. Though she did not seek out confession as alternative treatment, she was pleased to discover the ritual’s healing effects. Amanda describes a near total physical recovery from her diagnosed chronic illness since she began attending confession regularly. Now able to walk again, without any difficulty or pain, she attributes her incredible rehabilitation and the complete

restoration of her physical health to the ritual's transformation of her sick [immoral] body into a healthy [moral] one. The profound awesomeness of this outcome is further compounded by the prior failures of modern medicine in addressing her condition.

*I was kind of in awe, especially as a person whose **body was so sick** that the sacraments are actually these **tangible, like gifts of grace that are for our bodies**, because Jesus knows that we're weak... it is a very actual, tangible thing that the sacraments are... they do **sustain me**. They do **nourish me**. They do **heal me**. You know. You continue to offer yourself again and again and again, and that matters. - Amanda, lay parishioner*

These powerful accounts of confession demonstrate the ritual's ability to actively (re)construct and rehabilitate the lived body. However, this transformation is not limited by the bounds of individual embodiment, and is experienced collectively when acknowledged through changes in penitents' physical appearances. The most internalistic interviewees not only turn inward to locate evidence of their sinfulness or forgiveness, but also insist that it is reflected outwardly, as visible to those around them. Penitents describe comments from others who can "tell" they've been to confession by their "attractive" and "glowy" exterior afterwards. The embodied make-over interviewees receive in the ritual, produces aesthetic signifiers of their improved (im)morality. Interviewees explain these "attractive" appearances by describing their diverse physical attributes. However, all accounts consistently emphasize confession's ability to facilitate drastic corporeal transformations that provoke significant and complimentary attention from others who corroborate its embodied effects.

*I think we've talked about the lightness, but there's also a light... **A light and a glowiness**, I think, about me... - Barbara, lay minister*

*I come out of confession... and he [her brother] looked at me, and he said, "**You look so good,**" ... there was just this joy in his eyes, and **he literally could see that I had been to confession**. - Amanda, lay parishioner*

*It's hard to describe... because it gives you something around you that— emits a sense of peace and contentment that may or may not be **attractive** to people, but...once you feel that way, it emulates—emits to those around you, I feel like... **you must be emitting something that people like, or feel good about.** - Michael, lay minister*

Knowledge of interviewees' sinfulness is recognized and reproduced as explicitly corporeal; tangible and visual evidence of which is recognized intrapersonally, and further reified interpersonally. These interactions affirm (im)morality as intrinsic to the lived body, which effectively solidifies the logic of both confession and the Church as legitimate, reasonable, and universal. This frame therefore reflects the most complete, and deepest embodiment of (im)morality by interviewees. The dialectical process of locating sin as a part of the body becomes a collective, social endeavor that extends far beyond individual introspection; as others are active participants in helping penitents and the Church transform their lived bodies.

Regardless of the degree to which it is internalized, all interviewees describe confession as a fundamentally embodied experience. The somatic sensations of sin and forgiveness they describe, situate evidence of their (im)morality as essentially corporeal. Interviewees rely on confession and the Church for the exclusive forgiveness that extricates sin from their lived bodies— a process defined by their *observable* embodiment of (im)morality. Both the ritual, and the institution thereby become necessary for penitents' survival— not only morally, but also physiologically. Interviewees describe feeling “reborn,” “saved,” and revived by confession.

*... the Lord is **bringing you back to life**, spiritually. - Father Paul, priest of 6 years*

While this transformation may be spiritual, it is also deeply embodied. Some penitents detail how confession literally saved their lives, and credit the ritual [and the Church] with their survival. For instance, Phil discussed struggles with substance abuse and drug addiction throughout his adult life. Regularly using alcohol and prescription pain medication culminated in tenuous or

broken relationships, and severe depression. He recounted attempting suicide in his home, which was also the day he entered a substance abuse program for counseling and rehabilitation. In order to start his new, sober life, Phil— a lifelong Catholic— felt he first needed to attend confession to be forgiven of his sinful actions and addiction. Today, he credits this reversionary and profound experience with his survival, and continued sobriety.

***I was reborn that day. I was saved...** when I surrendered myself to Christ. But, my rebirth into the faith, **my rebirth into Catholicism**— happened that day in that chapel with that reconciliation that I had. That confession was incredible. Incredible!... **I was reborn!**... I was without sin. I was able to operate how God needed me to. - Phil, lay parishioner*

Able to “operate” how God needs him to, Phil’s experience illustrates penitents’ embodied dependence on the ritual as a means of not only moral, but also emotional, psychological, and physical transformation. Individuals effectively owe their spiritual and actual lives to confession and the Church; perpetually reliant on the ritual and institution as sole purveyors of necessary moral and corporeal relief.

Though interviewees are distinguished by their use of either external or internal discursive frames, all explain the experience of confession as essentially embodied. Sin and the Church never truly exist “outside” interviewees, and already *live* within their bodies. These categories are therefore continuous, and flow together at various intersections. Even the most subtle distinctions between interviewees’ accounts reflect significant differences in how they experience and understand the same ritual. Rather than terminally (re)producing penitents’ total subjectivity, these nuances are evidence that confession is a reflexive interaction, in which penitents exercise considerable agency. Interviewees demonstrate how they (re)shape the Church’s moral logic, by articulating how it (re)shapes them through diverse, and highly personalized discursive frames.

Though it is not entirely precluded by the ritual, penitents' agency is significantly constrained. Interviewees define sin, forgiveness, confession, priests, and penitents in different ways; conceptualizing each of these key elements through the lens of their individual identities. However, interviewees' descriptions share a glaring similarity. In all of their frames— external and internal— the Church's role remains entirely absent. Though they compare sin to sickness, penitents to patients, confession to surgery, priests to doctors, and forgiveness to healing, interviewees do not include the Church in any of their discursive scaffoldings; completely disregarding its presence, actions, and influence. Along with their actual experiences, this omission reflects interviewees' firm belief in their embodied, sole, and direct liability for their (im)morality. This powerful combination ensures the Church's long term survival as an institution— insulated from blame, and essential for life.

God's (Final) Exam: Origins and Implications of Confession's Ritual Structure

Penitents' moral externalism, internalism, and fundamentally *corporeal* sense of sin, does not occur by accident. The functions of confession are directly analogous to its structure. Both the individual embodied effects of the ritual, and its institutional value are the product of a unique and highly systematic procedure.¹⁰ The structure of this performance establishes and encourages penitents' belief in their embodied (im)morality, which confession is intended to address through a specific sequence of intrapersonal and interpersonal interactions. Interviewees explicitly acknowledge the ritual's purpose of (re)constructing their lived bodies— demonstrating a keen awareness of, and intense *desire for* the Church's active efforts to reform them morally, and corporeally. Grace, a cradle Catholic who still attends confession regularly, argues that penitents are “not meant to leave” confession as the “same person” they were before the ritual.

¹⁰ See this study's subsection, entitled, *Practicing Confession: Forgiveness in Three Steps*, for a detailed overview of the ritual's script and practical procedure.

You're not meant to leave the same person, as when you walked in... - Grace, lay parishioner

This institutional agenda is clear to interviewees, who openly affirm the transformational objective of confession. Their embodied experiences demonstrate that moral reconstruction is not a passive, spiritual process that can be left to God alone. Rather, the roles of priests and penitents are carefully defined to ensure the ritual functions effectively to forgive sins. Each participant has certain duties they must fulfill so that confessions meet institutional expectations and structural standards. In this way, the ritual requires embodied performances by both priests and penitents, alike. All of the details of their respective roles are defined by the Church, which prescribes specific actions, words, and even emotions.

While interviewees identified and described the performative essence of confession, it was most clearly illustrated by ethnographic experiences of the interviews themselves. In this unique setting, several interviewees were unsure about their individual and institutional obligations when discussing the ritual. The open-endedness of our conversations was a source of frequent confusion, and significant bodily discomfort that was palpable. This was especially apparent during interviews in which priests articulated or displayed anxiety about balancing the self-disclosure of their personal experiences, with their educational and evangelical duties as Church employees. The unstructured co-articulation of personal and institutional descriptions of confession seemed to upset the normal power dynamics of the ritual; causing interviewees to feel as though they lacked sufficient authority and knowledge to participate in our conversation.

Without clear requirements for their performance, priests negotiated the ambiguity of the interview setting by using several different strategies. For instance, Father Patrick and I met in his private office, behind closed doors. Upon entering the room, he refused to begin the interview until we prayed together. After finishing the blessing, he stood behind an adjustable table which

he raised to the height of a pulpit. When I sat in the low chair in front of him, he began “preaching” from the notes and research about confession he prepared, and printed on several sheets of paper. I thanked Father Patrick for such an extensive background on the ritual, and asked him to tell me about his own experiences with confession. While at an immediate loss for words, his bodily comportment provided a revealing response. As Father Patrick— who immigrated to the United States during college— began telling me about his childhood in a rural village colonized and evangelized by Irish Catholic priests, he also reconverted his “pulpit” to a small table, and sat down in his chair. Though Father Patrick’s anxiety remained palpable, his comportment and demeanor appeared casual, open, and vulnerable. Throughout the interview, he continued to oscillate between standing at his “pulpit” while preaching about confession, and sitting across from me while disclosing intimate personal experiences with the ritual.

Other priests expressed less ambivalence in their embodied reactions to the absence of institutional guidelines for our conversation. Father Nick did not hesitate to impose the rules of confession on the interview structure— despite the poor interpersonal fit. Rather than embracing self-disclosure like Father Patrick— albeit only at certain moments— he sought to firmly (re)assert his authority, leaving little room for deviation from the dyadic structure of confession. While his efforts were pervasive throughout our conversation, Father Nick’s most explicit attempt at reclaiming his priestly role came when he assigned me penance for the interview.

*So, young lady, **before we leave, I'm gonna give you your penance...** you're gonna pray, what is called the Surrender Novena... But I just want you to pray Day 5. - Father Nick, priest of 23 years*

In the absence of a script to guide him, Father Nick made a blatant attempt to impose the structure of confession on our conversation. Unsure about how to interact with me outside of the ritual itself, he relied on his prior embodied knowledge for direction. This manifested in

assigning me prayers to say as penance, even though I never confessed anything to him; allowing Father Nick to reclaim his rightful institutional status by relegating me to that of penitential subjectivity. Changes in Father Patrick's comportment signaled shifts in the performance of his priestly identity, where standing at the pulpit functioned as a symbolic embodied display of his institutional authority. Similarly, assigning me "penance" was Father Nick's strategy to (re)claim his priestly power as an agent of not only the Church, but God Himself. Reminding me that he was acting in a "divine" capacity allowed Father Nick to assert the validity of his discursive contributions as unquestionable products of God's work through him— rather than his subjective, personal opinions.

Alongside interviewees' verbal accounts, these unique dynamics demonstrate that confession is a systematic embodied performance in which each actor must play a specific role. Fulfilling these duties is incredibly important, and shapes every aspect of priests' and penitents' participation. The ritual's unique structure closely regulates expressions of power and subjectivity that strengthens penitents' dependence on the Church by cementing their belief in their essentially embodied (im)morality.

Performing Embodied Agency and Subjectivity

Confession is only effective in facilitating penitents' moral transformations when priests and penitents play their assigned roles correctly, adhering to a systematic ritual structure that aligns with institutional expectations. Interviewees articulate their understanding of the essential actions, words, motivations, and dispositions required for an appropriate performance of their respective identities. However, the rules for priests and penitents demand extremely different corporeal and discursive labor— with embodied authenticity being a threat to the former, and primary goal of the latter.

Paradoxically, the defining characteristic of priests' role is their performance of *strategic disembodiment*. Catholic teaching reflects that priests act "in persona christi," or "in the place of Christ" while hearing confessions.¹¹ The institution defines them as entirely passive instruments that God uses to communicate with penitents, directly; unable to act, think, speak, or feel freely while embodying the identity and presence of Christ. As a well established facet of Church doctrine, nearly all interviewees defined priests' role in the ritual this way. Both priests and parishioners consistently asserted that confession is an interaction with God, not the Church. Father Peter articulated the specifics of his (dis)embodied experiences as a confessor, only "entering the picture" when he verbalizes the Prayer of Absolution.

*... it's a dynamic between the penitent and Christ. **I enter the picture only when I declare the absolution** ... "Lord, **I'm shutting up at the moment**. I know exactly what I think. I know exactly what I wanna do. And isn't that wonderful? And now **I'm sitting completely aside**. And I want you to **give me your eyes to see, your ears to hear, your heart to understand**— and then inspire me with the good I'm supposed to do here." - Father Peter, priest of over 10 years*

Priests do not claim to "be" or "become" God in the ritual, and instead describe an experience similar to possession; relinquishing control of their own mental, emotional, and physical faculties to allow God's operation through their "eyes," "ears," and "hearts." These accounts become less theoretical, and more tangible through priests' sensory observations as confessors; detailing their embodied experiences of God bypassing their volitional capacities during, and after the ritual. Exiting the confessional, they are confounded and perplexed by their ability to offer penitents helpful, pertinent advice. Priests' descriptions of their involuntary and unconscious involvement in the ritual are pervasive throughout these data, and articulated through strikingly similar language; often rhetorically asking where their words and actions "came from."

¹¹ See this study's subsection, entitled, *Practicing Confession: Forgiveness in Three Steps*, for a further explanation of this doctrinal concept.

*A lot of times I don't think about it 'till afterwards. Like, "How did I— **how did I say that? How did I think of that?**" - Father Luke, priest of 4 months*

*I just found myself saying the things that people needed to hear. Which I didn't plan for. That's the thing— like, I do find that sometimes advice works, and I use it again and again. But then **oftentimes I— I just say what needs to be said, and I don't know where that comes from.** - Father John, priest of 30 years*

*I got out of the room, and I said, which I've said a hundred-thousand times in my life, since, "**Where did that come from?**"... **There's no way, shape, or form, and I can internally, credibly, credibly take credit for any of that.** That would be such a lie. Such a lie. And **I like being surprised** by that again, and again, and again... you just know what to say and do... **You just find yourself doing it.** - Father Peter, priest of over 10 years*

In addition to reasserting the Church's theological reasoning, priests also develop personal narratives to convince others that they lack agency in the ritual. These interviewees employ different strategies to establish the impossibility of their involvement, diminishing their individual experience, intelligence, and wisdom. Like Father Paul and Father Ian, both of whom are relatively young priests, confessors claim their life experience, intelligence, and "wisdom" are insufficient to affect the moral transformations they witness in the ritual.

*... this happens probably almost every time I hear confessions— someone will leave the confession, and I'll say, "**Where did that come from?**" Like just the advice 'cause there's, I mean— I'm 33, you know, I'm— **my life experience is still pretty limited**... And so there are times when people are going through stuff, and they leave. And I'm like, "How did I have— where did that— **that's not my wisdom,**" I guess, is my point. **That's clearly not something that I just knew**... - Father Paul, priest of 6 years*

*You know, **I say things that are wiser than I am**... What I say— you notice it in the moment, but sometimes I look at it, and I'm like, "**Where did that come from?** That was really good, and **that wasn't me.**" It's like, "**I'm not that smart.**" [laughter] - Father Ian, priest of 4 years*

Through this self-deprecation, priests effectively perform *strategic disembodiment* by fabricating their individual incompetence to indirectly substantiate the ritual's validity. Rather than reflecting their inadequacy as confessors, priests' practical arguments are constructed to vitiate the

possibility of their agency. While the Church makes it clear they should not consider their personal emotions and opinions in response to penitents' confessions, priests' narrative contributions are intended to prove they functionally cannot. Ethically, theologically, and physiologically precluded from acting freely in confession, priests are able to appropriately perform their institutional obligations.

Despite these elaborate constructions of their lack of agency, interviewees describe corporeal evidence of priests' personal freedom and actions in confession. Instead of unthinking, unfeeling instruments, confessors' individual dispositions, personalities, and methods affect the experience of confession, and provoke specific embodied responses. Penitents describe how these unique circumstances influence their decisions before, and during the ritual. Interviewees are "picky" about their confessors; both how intimately they know and *are known by* particular priests, leads them to purposely select some and evade others altogether. Grace and Jeremy, both college students who were raised Catholic, describe instances in which their relational proximity to specific priests influenced their decisions to avoid them as confessors. These interviewees expressed others', and their own anxiety about how disclosing their sins might affect what priests "think" of them, long term.

*... my mom didn't like to go with him because she's like, "No, **we see him too often. I don't want him to be the priest in confession.**"* - Grace, lay parishioner

***I was always self-conscious of what this priest thinks about me.** So I never went to my home parish priest, I always went to someone else.* - Jeremy, lay parishioner

These parishioners describe how their personal relationships with priests outside of confession shape their experiences. However, their interactions within the ritual itself are just as impactful. The unique methods and strategies priests demonstrate play a significant role in the quality of penitents' confessions. When reflecting on his past experiences, Jason, who considers himself an

expert on Catholicism and the ritual, distinguished between “good” and bad confessors; where the former are able to keep him “on the right track.”

*... you need to confess often so **your confessor— if they're good— knows who you are, knows to give you good advice** on how to maneuver the pitfalls... Father [Patrick] is very good— he knows what to say to keep me on the right track... - Jason, lay parishioner*

Interviewees clearly recognize priests’ individual identities, personalities, methods, and relational histories as important factors influencing their embodied experiences of confession. Contrary to the institutional construction of priests’ role as passive and inconsequential, they operate in an entirely subjective fashion. The practical efficacy and viability of confession in facilitating and encouraging penitents’ continued participation, rests on priests’ discursive denial and *strategic disembodiment* of their individual agency.

In addition to penitents, priests themselves acknowledge the reality of their free will and undiminished volitional capacities; recognizing the impact of their personal identities on the ritual’s function and structure. Priests describe their positive emotional, psychological, and physical responses to different penitents and circumstances, as confessors. These interviewees reference satisfaction with their performances, identifying moments they felt well-equipped to hear confessions, and gratified by their ability to improve penitents’ lives. Some priests, like Father Mark, compare their feelings after confession to other relationships that provide similar emotional fulfillment, comparing their role in the ritual to a “good father.”

*And **I’m just so happy**. And I feel like a— **I feel like a good father**, you know? - Father Mark, priest of 3 years*

Father Alex asserts this far more directly, and acknowledges his individual agency as not only possible, but necessary; imagining confession would easily become “overwhelming” without it.

***It would be awful [to hear confessions] if you couldn't do anything about it. [laughter] ... that would be overwhelming...** - Father Alex, priest of 6 years*

In these moments, priests affirm their ability to “do something” about penitents’ (im)morality. Through confession, they possess the individual agency and authority to help individuals extricate sin from their lived bodies. Priests are not only aware of this capacity to affect others through the ritual, but also value it personally. As a result, they are also impacted when certain aspects of their performances seem to fall short of both individual and institutional standards. Priests describe more negative experiences as confessors, feeling “inadequate,” unhelpful, or unprepared to respond to penitents’ sins.

*... **I felt inadequate.** I felt like, “Okay what do I do with this...” - Father John, priest of 30 years*

*... there's a time when I'd argue with my sister one time, you know, it's just like— and thinking, “Well, **who am I to sit in this confession?** I just had a shouting match with my sister...” - Father Paul, priest of 6 years*

While Father John expressed concern about his abilities, Father Paul grapples with a distinctly ethical dilemma; acknowledging his personal role in absolving penitents’ sins by his feelings that it would be hypocritical for him to do so. By all accounts, priests’ personal dispositions, sensations, and reactions are not subject to God’s control, and influence the quality of their embodied performances as confessors. Priests’ personal, subjective experiences of confession are shaped by their individual identities and environmental circumstances. Hearing penitents’ sins produces real, somatic responses that are either enjoyable and exciting, or draining and tiresome. Father Ian and Father Luke, both of whom are new to the priesthood, confirm Father Alex’s depiction of confession as a potentially “overwhelming” experience; describing opposite effects of equally profound intensity. Father Ian feels “energized” by the “rush” confession provides, as an “exciting” and invigorating interaction with penitents.

It depends on how tired I am! [laughter]... the more confessions I hear– I have to say– the more energized I get... if I'm really tired, but then I hear 10 confessions, I feel a lot more awake at the end, because it was exciting. “Rush” isn't the right word, but like excitement... - Father Ian, priest of 4 years

Father Luke, a less experienced confessor, explains an entirely different response, feeling depleted by the mentally exhausting task of remembering and responding to penitents' sins—especially those who are “long-winded.”

I mean, it's— in the moment, it can be a little more draining because you have to— you have to keep track of what— how to try to give advice, and sometimes you have words to help people. Sometimes you don't, but mentally, it can be a little bit exhausting in the moment... trying to remember those [sins] so that you can speak to them, and offer advice, especially if they're really long winded. Let's say there's spending 5, 10 minutes in there, like, you gotta remember, “I gotta say this thing. Oh, that's— nope— that's another third thing I gotta remember.”... sometimes you don't— I don't feel like I have the right words... - Father Luke, priest of 4 months

Whether they are positive or negative, interviewees demonstrate that confession involves and requires embodied, personal interactions between priests and penitents. Despite their creative narrative constructions, priests do not experience the ritual as passive instruments, controlled by God. As confessors, they freely act and respond to penitents' disclosures of sin. The corporeal labor of their priestly role is motivated and shaped by their personal emotions, knowledge, and experiences; which penitents' fully acknowledge as influential factors in their own participation.

The reality of priests' free will and agency seems to contradict the ritual's systematic structure, prescribed by the Church. However, the practical exercise and impact of priests' highly individualized interpretations of their role as confessors, is essential to the ritual and the institution. The Church demands that priests perform *strategic disembodiment* in confession; diminishing their personal agency while strategically asserting it to control the outcome of

penitents' experiences. Though logically incoherent, this unique ontological duality equips priests to accomplish important institutional objectives.

Learning and Evaluating Embodied Performances

Priests' paradoxical performance in confession is inherently complex and requires significant embodied labor. As a result, extensive training is required to play their unique role appropriately, preserving the ritual's institutional function and structure. Priests recounted their experiences attending seminary, where they received a thorough education on how to facilitate confession. Through repeated and supervised practice in an intensive course or "practicum," priests learned specific tactics and honed their skills as confessors. In addition to classroom instruction, priests participated in mock confessions as seminarians, during which they practiced their assigned roles for the first time. Their instructors and peers helped create life-like scenarios intended to replicate the actual experience of confession. Priests' ability to apply the strategies they were taught, and their own intuition to respond to hypothetical penitents, was assessed and graded. Based on the scores and qualitative feedback they received, priests often revised their communicative tactics to become more effective confessors. While several priests described such experiences, Father Ralph provided the most detailed overview of the learning process.

*Well, the basic teaching, or the way of teaching hearing confessions is what's called a practicum. Which they just set up— **it's kind of like a— putting on a play.** One of the seminarians is the confessor; another one is the penitent and say, "Okay, here's the situation. **Based on what you've learned through the classroom teaching, and in your own intuition, how would you handle this?**" And we have a confession. And the instructor, who— my instructor was Father [redacted], who is now retired, but very good instructor. He's kind of sitting off in the corner where we can't see him, with a clipboard, saying, "Okay. How did this confession go?... And then we— he would sit down and discuss with us **where we did good, where we made mess ups**, you know, or sometimes it was just a complete Chinese fire drill, and **maybe we shouldn't put you in the confessional.** But, say, okay, "You did this, this and this, but you also did this and this." And **he would give us the evaluation sheet.** And then that evening, after our evening prayers, we would be in our rooms, and looking it over and thinking, "Okay, how would I*

*handle this again?"... Well, it was just, you know, you were a little too harsh in this instance, you know. Maybe you should have said something more along the lines of this way, instead of the way you put it. Sometimes, **"You are awfully accusatory in your tone," meaning, "You didn't welcome this person in."** - Father Ralph, priest of 11 years*

The Church's pedagogical practices and strategies firmly establish confession as a systematic, embodied performance. Like a "play," seminarians and their instructors design, produce, and rehearse different interpersonal interactions. The institution prepares priests for potential communicative and relational obstacles that may arise throughout the ritual, and coaches them to strategically respond in certain ways. While the Church doesn't provide them with a literal, written script— as it does for penitents— priests' role is as rigid as it is subjective. Creative reproductions of the ritual reflect the institutional expectation that penitents' experiences are dynamic and fluid, rather than mechanical and uniform. Priests are encouraged and instructed to combine the Church's strategies with their own experiences, knowledge, and intuition when responding to penitents. The most effective and highly valued performances are those in which confessors are able to strike an embodied balance between institutional tactics, and their individual agency. Father Ralph further described how he was taught to hear confessions, and referenced specific feedback he received from instructors; revealing how the ritual is structured by the Church's logic to "welcome" individuals into the institution.

*... if you don't **welcome them into the confessional**, how can you expect to **welcome them into the church**?... - Father Ralph, priest of 11 years*

He explains how this objective shapes his practical methods and strategies as a confessor, identifying how he manages his actions and appearance throughout the ritual. Father Ralph describes a second embodied paradox priests must negotiate in confession— in addition to the strategic disembodiment through which they deny their individual agency. Priests must also [inauthentically] *perform* authenticity for the ritual to be successful; downplaying their personal

and institutional influence on its structure to build rapport, and ensure penitents “trust” them enough to be comfortable disclosing their sins.

*... they would give us example— different examples of how that would look, you know, but in the end we would have— **being different individuals— we would have to come up with our own way**... because a lot of penitents, when they come in, **they can sense if you're being artificial** as well, “Oh, he's just doing this from what he read in the book.”*

*... they kind of **loosen up**, instead of sitting there all rigid... they're **more than willing to relieve themselves** of whatever is troubling them, because **they know I can be trusted**...*

***I'm very relaxed** when I'm— I'm, you know, I have an armchair in there with, you know— just kind of **sitting there at ease**, and, you know, **not a stern visage on my face**, and just say, “Good afternoon. What would you like to talk about today?” Just— **very calm voice**. No, you know, **no grimace on my face**. No, “What are you here for?” and, you know, “What did you do wrong this time?”... **I don't even use the word confession**... it automatically seems like I'm pointing my finger at them: “Confess! Confess!” It's like, no. That— that puts them on their guard, and they won't... **I don't have the kindest natural look on me**, you know. I— ask any little kid. I'm— **I'm not tall, but I'm large. And so they're automatically intimidated by this [gestures to body]. That's why I have to go out of my way to show them what's underneath it...** Try to smile without being frightening in the smile. - Father Ralph, priest of 11 years*

Father Ralph describes an intensely self-conscious process of managing and monitoring his nonverbal communication, bodily comportment, and personal appearance to encourage penitents' disclosures of sin. In order to “welcome” penitents into confession, and thus into the Church, priests must engage in significant corporeal self-discipline. Father Ralph explains how the institution has not only shaped his body in confession, but has also taught him how to continuously (re)shape it himself. Priests' performances are only appropriate and effective after they've identified and analyzed parts of their lived bodies that threaten to complicate or hinder their ability to achieve certain institutional goals. Father Ralph's concerns about his “intimidating” size, facial expressions, demeanor, and tone of voice, illustrate how confession's efficacy depends on specific displays of curated corporeality that have symbolic, moralized

meanings. Priests' role in confession requires them to strike a delicate, and often precarious, balance between the simultaneous denial and performance of their authentic agency and corporeality. In this way, priests' lived body's are (re)constructed to support the ritual's structure, and preserve its efficacy in different contexts and circumstances. Priests' strategic embodied *and* disembodied performances are not sufficient to facilitate and sustain confession on its own. As a part of their institutional duties, they must not only manage their own embodied authenticity, but also evaluate that of others. To ensure the ritual satisfies the Church's functional expectations, priests must evaluate how well they have performed their own role while simultaneously evaluating the appropriateness of penitents' performances. Father Ralph identified problematic aspects of his personal appearance and comportment, which he edited in various ways to prevent penitents from perceiving him as inauthentic, intimidating, or "accusatory." Priests apply that same logic when observing penitents' embodiment of (im)morality, and look for corporeal evidence of penitents' contrition to discern whether their vulnerability is genuine.

*So— but we still have the screen. But you can hear fidgeting, too. Most are— most of our kneelers in reconciliation, **rooms have vinyl covering, so we can hear fidgeting. When people fidget, that means they're uneasy. They're not comfortable with what they're saying.** And it's not the discomfort of, "Oh, I did something really bad." **It's the discomfort of, "Yeah, this really isn't kind of the truth."** But they don't know they're doing it. It's just like, you know, **a poker player with a nervous tick.** If you pick up on that, **you can read whether they have a winning or losing hand,** because they're unaware of it. So it's just, you know, little— **little keys.** - Father Ralph, priest of 11 years*

Priests' extreme hypervigilance clearly extends beyond the management of their own bodies, to the evaluation of penitents' as a metric of confession's functional efficacy. Even without seeing them directly, priests describe a keen awareness of "little keys" they use to judge the quality of penitents' performances within the interaction. The Church thus uses the lived body as a critical indicator of moral transformation. Priests describe their strategies for determining the ritual's

efficacy, and moralize both verbal and nonverbal elements of penitents' performances to identify differences in their embodiment before, and after confession. Both Father Nick, and Father Alex— a far less experienced confessor— describe the “transformations” they witness through examples of embodied changes in penitents' emotional and physical states. Before the ritual, these priests observe crying, exasperated sighs, and particular tones of voice as corporeal evidence of penitents' immorality. Afterwards, they attribute tangible shifts in penitents' bodily appearances and comportment to confession's success in facilitating God's forgiveness.

*And then once I give them their penance, and finally give them absolution, right, the— the power of the sacrament. Once they hear the— the words of absolution that they're forgiven of all their sins, Father, Son, Holy Spirit, **I have a different person before my eyes. I see the transformation.** Nobody else sees that. I see that— which is very, very uplifting for me. Because **I see someone who's scared, who's worried, who is fearful, who's bound up by sin. They're crying. They're angry, they're agitated, whatever it may be, but at the end of it, I see transformation.** I don't see the scared person. I don't see the fearful person. I don't see the person crying. Now, it's like there's a— there's a weight that just— been lifted off their shoulders. - Father Nick, priest of 23 years*

*Yeah, I mean, **you can hear it in people's voices** sometimes, if, like, there's kind of a deep sigh of [demonstrates sigh] like almost this **physical exhalation**, you know, like, this is just a deep sigh of like, “Yeah, I did this again.” or— **it's just like really obvious that they're carrying a lot**, you know... I mean you just see, in like a really short span of time, the person who **comes in with like deep sigh of exasperation and leaves with a deep sigh of relief**, you know, we just there's there's not always, but sometimes a very perceptible **change in demeanor and tone of voice.** - Father Alex, priest of 6 years*

These accounts reveal how priests articulate and understand the ritual's efficacy through the lens of penitents' bodies. Priests interpret their actions, appearances, and voices as concrete evidence of (im)morality, and whether they were actually transformed by confession.

Penitents' embodied performances are not left up to chance, however. The Church carefully defines their role, and structures every aspect of their systematic participation in the ritual. Like priests, they undergo extensive training and preparation to ensure they are able to

execute this performance in practice. Interviewees' formal education in Catholic schools and RCIA (Rights of Catholic Initiation for Adults) programs was generally forgettable, insignificant, or unremarkable, having little impact on their embodied knowledge of confession. Instead, they noted experiences similar to those of seminarians while learning about the ritual; practicing their role in hypothetical, "play" confessions before attending real ones. Penitents' performances are far more rigid than priests', as they are required to memorize a "formula" of scripted actions, words, and even emotions. Elaine, who was raised in the Church and attended Catholic schools, recalls these experiences "practicing" confession with her teacher, so that it would not be "scary" when she attended with a priest for the first time.

***We had a formula we had to memorize**... yeah. "Bless me, Father, for I have sinned. It has been so many weeks since my last confession. These are my sins," and then you'd list them. And then there was another prayer after that— I don't think we said the Act of Contrition. These— yeah, I don't remember the end. I remember the beginning... we had to memorize that, and then we would go to church, and **we would have to practice it**, and Sister was in the confessional, and we would have— we'd take turns going in, **so it wouldn't be scary**, or you know. - Elaine, lay minister*

This practical education was incredibly important to interviewees' preparation for, and participation in the ritual. During these mock confessions, penitents had the opportunity to rehearse their embodied performances as contrite sinners. Memorizing the literal and social script for their interaction with the priest, allowed them to fulfill their institutionally defined responsibilities. The value of this embodied practice is underscored by interviewees' descriptions of how they struggle to negotiate the ritual without it. Whether institutional or personal obstacles prevented their adequate preparation, penitents experienced intense anxiety and shame about their unsatisfactory performances. As a child, Randall "missed" the opportunity to practice confession at his Catholic school, because his mother kept him home while he was sick. Never having learned what is expected from penitents throughout the "process," Randall is persistently

troubled by his inability to participate appropriately in the ritual.

*Right from the start, **I missed exactly how you do it... so that never felt right...** Well, you know, **there's a process.** You go and you got to do this and do that, and I never really knew... I missed all that schooling or catechism at that time— it's kind of a big deal, **you've got to spend some time on it.** And once you do— there's some prayer. I just remember the word "detest"-- 'I detest all my sins,' or whatever. And I always had a lot of trouble memorizing that— I knew my Hail Marys and Our Fathers, but that— for some reason— **I couldn't memorize that one... I didn't like that.** - Randall, lay parishioner*

As Elaine and Randall describe, penitents' performances are systematically structured, and require rigorous corporeal preparation and effort. Without adequate practice and training, they are unable to participate in the ritual through the correct actions, comportment, and dispositions. While learning about and practicing confession was a mundane obligation for interviewees, they also acknowledged it as essential preparation for their embodied performances. Similar to priests, memorizing and rehearsing their role, allows penitents to be effective in accomplishing the ritual's objectives.

Unlike priests, however, the Church requires penitents assume the additional burden of self-evaluation. Though interviewees' descriptions clearly establish priests' active judgment of their participation, the structure of confession precludes penitents from receiving any feedback, directly. Unsure of where they "messed up" or "did good," interviewees describe their systematic scrupulosity when determining how well they performed. In a particularly detailed analogy, Elizabeth compared confession to an exam. Growing up, her Catholic education allowed her to "study" by learning how to examine her conscience, and adhere to the ritual's script. The real "test" is disclosing her sins to the priest, following the correct words and actions. Afterwards, she "grades" her performance based on specific institutional criteria, and identifies areas she could improve. Priests' advice and assignment of penance effectively guides her "revisions" while she begins preparing for her next confession.

*Kind of like preparing for an exam. You're just like, "Let me do as best as I can with the knowledge that I have."... then you go into an examination of conscience... they gave you all of the knowledge you need to make that exam, but some of it kind of went in one ear, and out the other, or missed your notes somehow. And so, **you're just praying that you collected enough information to do the best on that exam that you can do.** And then, of course, when you're sitting there, either writing things out or filling in the number circles... you don't know how it's going to turn out. You're just trying to answer the best that you can and hope that... when they go through the exam, and they're reading it, and they're looking at the numbers, that when you get it back, it's got an A plus on it, because that's what you want. **Sometimes it comes back with a B or a C, and it doesn't mean that you failed, F is failing... it's kind of the same with confession. You go in for the exam, you tell the priest, you know, and God sees and hears everything, but you might not have said everything, it's just not in your brain. It's not that you were restricting in any way... and you don't even think about it until you're walking out of the confessional, and then you go, "Oops, I forgot about this."** And then, if you're like me, you write it on a sticky note for next time. But the thing is, **God doesn't give you a graded paper back for that exam.** It's whatever you brought to him, he forgives you of... His exam is, "Know what you want to bring me, and I'll take care of it."... **Deciphering how you did in confession is a lot harder than just getting an exam back, that's for sure.** But, it does have a lot to do with how you are doing, because there are times where I've walked out of confession, and I'm like, "I've confessed everything that I had. That was good!" But then **later on, if I remember something that I forgot, it's like, "Oh, that just depleted my grade a little bit.** But, I'm gonna make sure I've got it on there for next time." And if it's something really bad, then it's like, "Ope! I gotta plan next time for sooner, because I've gotta get that out of there!" But then, **if you walk out, and you don't have anything, at all, and if you've taken everything in, it's like, "I have done the best that I can do and the rest is up to God..."** - Elizabeth, lay parishioner*

Elizabeth illustrates penitents' heightened awareness of their embodied participation in confession. While priests' success as confessors depends on their ability to disguise individual agency as divine passivity, penitents' performances are evaluated on a more objective basis. For them, elements of appropriate embodiment are closely prescribed and rigidly defined by the Church. As a result, evaluating penitents is relatively straightforward. The incomplete disclosure of sins, inability to memorize the ritual script, or lack of (visible) contrition, all result in lower scores or a failing grade. Penitents conduct this evaluation *on their own*, without prompting or

direction from priests and the Church. In this way, penitents assume full responsibility for their embodied (im)morality; liable for both the sins they committed, and whether or not God will forgive them.

“Low Scoring” Performances

Interviewees’ experiences demonstrate priests’ and penitents’ abilities to affect the outcome of confession. The Church defines their respective roles, and requires extensive embodied training to preserve the ritual’s specific structure. When either fails to adequately fulfill their duties, the efficacy of confession is threatened. Penitents can only be forgiven when their communication and interpersonal exchange with confessors conforms to certain institutional standards. Failure to meet these structural requirements results in significant anxiety and concerns that interviewees’ moral transformations may be incomplete. Doubts about their confession’s final “score” or “grade” arise from several potential deficiencies in priests’ and penitents’ performances.

First, it is essential that confessors and penitents are able to understand each other. For the ritual to be effective, they must speak the same language, both literally and figuratively. However, language barriers often prevent priests or parishioners from grasping the substance of what is being said and done in the confessional. This was a relatively common experience among interviewees, where speaking or being spoken to in a foreign language resulted in a breakdown in communication. As penitents, interviewees were uncertain but only somewhat concerned with their confessor’s inability to understand their sins.

*I had a couple experiences where, like, **English is not the priest’s first language** and so I’m like, ‘**I don’t know how much he— like, you really got of that...**’ - Grace, lay parishioner*

*... as you get older, you get smart, and you’d go to the Polish priest **who didn’t really understand English**, and he’d always give you one Our Father, one Hail Mary, one Glory*

Be, no matter what you said. [laughter] - Elaine, lay minister

*Yes I did [go to the Irish priests for confession]... before, the Irish priests— before they would go to hear confession, as I said, **they could understand what you said, but they could not speak to us in our language.** I mean, they could just make a few sentences, you know, in our language... So, **they will hear most parts of the things that the people would say— if the priest wants to ask you questions, he can ask you questions in English.** And then **if you're able to respond, you can respond**... he would just give you the prayers that you needed to say. - Father Patrick, priest of 19 years*

From this perspective, linguistic incongruence doesn't appear to trouble penitents much at all. No matter how uncertain it was that confessors understood their sins, penitents depended on the reliability of their responses through uniform penances. Elaine even recalled openly exploiting this ambiguity, as an opportunity to avoid discussing her individual sins. For confessors, however, this miscommunication is a source of intense and significant anxiety. Father John explains feeling “inadequate” and uncomfortable forgiving penitents' sins when he did not know exactly which sins they confessed in a foreign language.

*For example, I had Vietnamese families in my past parish, and for the validity of the sacrament, **some of them couldn't say their sins in English, so I heard their confessions in Vietnamese, not knowing what in the world they were saying**... So, does that mean the sacrament is any less effective? ... I felt inadequate. I felt like, “Okay what do I do with this.. Um,” **not knowing if they committed murder, or they just had, like, ten bad thoughts**... [laughter]. - Father John, priest of 30 years*

Language barriers like the ones interviewees described raise interesting questions about confession's function under different structural conditions. If priests cannot understand penitents' sins, are they still forgiven? While the Church flatly dismisses language barriers as inconsequential to God's mercy, interviewees expressed doubts about their impact on the ritual's function and structure.

Other, more subjective barriers to communication also provide a basis for questioning confession's validity. Priests are not only ineffective confessors when speaking a language

literally foreign to penitents, but they must be *institutionally* fluent as well. Several interviewees expressed concerns that priests' use of different verbiage for absolution would diminish, or preclude God's forgiveness. For Jason, confessors that deviate from the Church's "rubric" are particularly worrisome, and grounds for questioning the ritual's validity.

*The priest only forgives you through the sacrament, through **the rubrics of the Church**, and even says, through the power of the Church ministry, right? He even says it. So if they don't, then actually, the— **if you have a priest that's not paying attention or doesn't care**, right— technically, now we're getting into some theological nodes here— **there's a chance that it might not be valid**. So again, I think people need to understand it's deeper than the priest... - Jason, lay parishioner*

Priests' inability to 'stick to the script' is as much as a threat to penitents' forgiveness, as their actual inability to understand which sins were confessed. For several interviewees, their capacity for embodied (im)morality rests on priests' adherence to the Church's "rubric" as the only means of procuring legitimate forgiveness from God.

Even in the absence of literal and institutional barriers, communication between priests and penitents may still break down, or fail to conform to institutional standards. More subjective than language, confessors evaluate penitents' embodied performances of contrition and genuine guilt for their sins. Even if they follow the ritual script correctly— saying and doing everything they are supposed to— priests' doubts about penitents' authenticity and sincerity may prevent them from receiving God's forgiveness, and therefore invalidate their confession. In addition to adequate verbal communication, interviewees' explained that penitents' must convey a sufficient degree of contrition through bodily demonstrations of guilt for, and comprehension of their wrongdoing. Theologically, priests' ostensible lack of agency bars them from withholding God's forgiveness because of their personal judgments. However, they still closely examine penitents' embodied performances for evidence to substantiate their deservingness. To determine whether

he can legitimately offer them God's forgiveness, Father Mark, a less experienced confessor, describes having to "pay attention" to penitents' embodied performances of moral anguish.

*And through that indelible mark... the priest has been given that authority to say, "Well, if you're not truly contrite, I can't forgive you... Jesus can't forgive you..." **Contrition is a huge part— and yeah, as a priest, I have to pay attention to that.** -Father Mark, priest of 3 years*

In this way, penitents must display their contrition and guilt corporeally; embodying an institutional fluency in confession. The ritual, and God's forgiveness is only real, tangible, and valid when their disclosure of sin is legible on all fronts; linguistically, institutionally, and spiritually. Determining the adequacy and depth of individual guilt, even when it is so concretely embodied, is a highly subjective endeavor. Though priests may have their own opinions and strategies, penitents do as well. Some interviewees explained the most ambiguous, and fearsome potential threat to confession's efficacy, and their capacity for moral transformation. Even when all aspects of the ritual conform to the Church's structural standards, and everyone plays their role correctly, these penitents are still skeptical about whether they have been forgiven. For them, institutional and even divine absolution is not enough; penitents must also forgive *themselves* for their sins, and remain vigilant in identifying corporeal evidence of their (im)morality. Michael, who attends confession as often as once a week, describes how he struggles to overcome this barrier and is unable to get sins "out of his head," no matter how long or hard he tries.

*If you believe everything they say about confession, it cleans your soul. And I think— not just the thought of a clean soul, but **in your mind and your body, you have to feel like, "I've confessed these sins, and they're gone."** And I had a really tough time with that... the priest would recognize it, and we would talk about that. And he said, "Man, you're— that sin is gone. It's wiped out." And I would say, "I know it is, but to me it was such a bad thing that **I can't get it out of my head.**" ... and I said, "**I can't get it out of my head.**" ... **there's certain things that I have a hard time forgiving myself for...** it's easy confessing it to a priest, but for him to say, "Okay it's gone, it's done." it's not quite that easy for humans... **it keeps coming into my consciousness, it's weird when you think***

*about it... well, why? **If it's forgiven, and I'm supposed to wipe it away, why can't I wipe it away?** So I pray about that; why does that keep coming back up, **why do I feel so bad about it, still, after all these years?** - Michael, lay minister*

In addition to recognizing their embodied sinfulness and immorality as corporeal deficiencies, interviewees, like Michael, also pathologize their inability to *feel forgiven*. Lingered guilt and ruminations about their wrongdoings long after confession, reflect and solidify penitents' perpetually deficient corporeality. Even God's forgiveness cannot fully free, cleanse, or heal them from sin. Through confession, penitents experience their immorality as so deeply and intrinsically embodied, that they ultimately conclude they are unforgivable. Some interviewees described their own, and others' feelings that it would be impossible to ever fully extricate sin from their lived bodies. Regardless of the functional and structural quality of their confessions, penitents must also believe they are worth forgiveness, in order to experience it somatically.

*... one of her biggest hang-ups— ironically— was **she [Phil's ex-wife] believed her sins were so great that she could not be forgiven**... I don't know where she got that mindset, but it destroyed her. **It destroyed her self-image**... somehow **she got it in her head that she wasn't forgiven, and she still believes that today**... - Phil, lay parishioner*

*... when you're losing hope, and when you're in that deep space of— where I was, at least... **not feeling like I was worth forgiving**. - Maria, lay parishioner*

These descriptions of interviewees' experiences and observations convey a significant degree of subjectivity. The source of penitents' sinfulness and immorality are so deeply embodied that their corporeal ties are unbreakable. This prevents them from *feeling* morally transformed, as they consider themselves too sinful to even be eligible for God's forgiveness in the first place.

Penitents' seemingly irrefutable belief in their bodily immorality is a striking conclusion, with serious analytical consequences. Even when confession meets all of the Church's complex, detailed requirements, persistent feelings of sinfulness and doubts about or complete denials of forgiveness call the ritual's purpose into question. Interviewees' embodied descriptions

demonstrate that confession is not simply an ephemeral moment of spiritual encounter. Rather, it involves both the institutional and *individual* (re)construction of their lived bodies. The Church goes to great lengths to ensure the ritual follows a rigid structure, and produces a specific outcome; requiring highly regulated, embodied performances by both confessors and penitents. Instead of forgiveness, the functional objective of confession is to create and sustain penitents' embodied subjectivity. Interviewees' descriptions establish penitents' belief that their (im)morality is intrinsically rooted in their lived bodies. Through inadequate performances in confession and embodied experiences of sinfulness, they are continuously able to find evidence that God has not forgiven them, and cannot. Interviewees detail this unique corporeal subjectivity, and trace its cultivation through their experiences preparing for and participating in confession. Though it is clear how the ritual functions, and is structured to (re)produce this particular Catholic body, a critical question remains unanswered. Similar to penitents' noticeable omissions from their moral externalization or internalization, the Church's institutional role and interests are undefined. Why might the Church seek to create and sustain penitents' belief in their embodied (im)morality? Stanley, an adult convert, and Father Ralph, a lifelong Catholic, offer a possible answer to this question; directly tying penitents' moralized corporeality and dependence on confession, to the Church's survival and growth as an institution.

*I think it's getting worse and worse in our society. People don't want to hear the truth. So the way you do that is, **you lead a good life that's attractive**, they ask about that, you **show them the beauty of the Catholic Church**, and then you **bring them into the truth of the Catholic Church**. - Stanley, lay parishioner*

*You want to **draw people in**, not push them out. - Father Ralph, priest of 11 years*

The primary objective of confession is to preserve and expand Church membership. When penitents experience sinfulness as inherent to their lived bodies, their dependence on confession

and the institution is cemented. This ensures and necessitates their lifelong reliance on the Church as a source of not only moral, but corporeal (re)construction and relief.

Catholic Psy-Ops: Confession's "Walking Advertisements"

Interviewees' embodied experiences of the ritual have three critical implications, providing a teleological map of its function, structure, and purpose. These descriptions help trace the Church's institutional (re)production of subjectivity to the level of individual embodiment. First, participating in confession leads penitents to blame themselves for sin, solely. As both moral externalists and internalists explained, they experience (im)morality viscerally; able to feel sinfulness and forgiveness as somatic sensations of heaviness and lightness, dirt and cleanliness, and sickness and health. Whichever framework they employ, penitents are plagued by feelings and knowledge of their moral and corporeal "abnormality."

*... you feel relieved [after confession] because you're like, "Wow, **maybe I'm not as abnormal— as messed up as the way I should be.**" - Stanley, lay parishioner*

Penitents' perpetual sense of their (im)morality is not merely a spiritual inclination. Through the ritual, sin and the body become one, integrated whole, indistinguishable from each other. Sinfulness is bodily, and the body is sinful. When individual (im)morality is systematically essentialized in this way, the institution is able to avoid all suspicion. Penitents do not attribute any aspect of their sinfulness to the Church. Without considering or understanding its role in cultivating their embodied scrupulosity, interviewees generally avoid broaching the subject altogether. On the rare occasion that they mentioned the institution's involvement in confession, interviewees construed it in a positive light; as it gratuitously extends penitents the repeated opportunity for much needed personal growth.

***We know we're going to do things that are sinful. So, what a great opportunity— how smart of the Church to allow us to come back and have this sacrament that we can celebrate to have our sins absolved.** - Barbara, lay minister*

Barbara, a faith formation director who prepares Catholic children and adult converts for confession, makes a powerful observation. The Church's use of confession to cultivate penitents' embodied subjectivity through corporealized (im)morality is indeed "smart." The categorical omission of the institution's actions, interests, and influence effectively renders it immune from any *vicarious* liability for penitents' sins and immorality. Instead, penitents assume personal, *direct* liability themselves; able to identify credible, supporting evidence that is exclusively embodied. Bearing this burden completely alone, and unable to extricate themselves from their moralized corporeal inadequacies, penitents continuously rely on confession, and the Church for relief. Interviewees demonstrated this dependence through accounts of their urgent desires to return to the ritual, and desperation for the forgiveness it provides. For Michael, these feelings are so intense that he has to "run to the confessional" because sin "drives [him] nuts."

*... they say you have to go once a year, but **I feel the need that— if I sin, I almost got to run. I mean, I've got to run to the confessional...** if I take the Lord's name in vain, **it drives me nuts**. But sometimes I get so frustrated, I do. And I hate it, I hate it. So I feel— well, you've probably heard this term— **I feel that Catholic guilt**. It's a real— it's a real thing. - Michael, lay minister*

Corporeal knowledge of immorality becomes so uncomfortable somatically— a sensation Michael describes as "Catholic guilt" — that penitents perpetually seek out the ritual for relief. This necessitates their attendance and participation far beyond what is recommended and required by the Church. Penitents thereby become complicit in the cultivation of their embodied subjectivity, as active and willing participants who repeatedly choose to facilitate their own corporeal (re)construction. As personally and solely liable for their sinfulness, penitents' bodies become living evidence of their (im)morality— or as Amanda described, "walking advertisements" for confession [and the Church].

I feel like I'm, like, kind of a walking advertisement for confession... if I had, like, a tagline for confession, I'd be like, "Did you know it's a gift?" - Amanda, lay parishioner

Interviewees' experiences reveal the Church's genius marketing strategy, and the functional purpose of confession; to create portable, 'walking,' subjects who embody the logic and value of the institution through their ostensibly intrinsic (im)morality. This is an involved, systematic process that affects and engages penitents' lived bodies. By all accounts, the Church's use of confession as a tool for individual, corporeal moralization is a targeted strategy, intended to (re)produce certain results [and bodies]. Sarah, a lifelong Catholic, asserts that her professional background as a military intelligence officer working in psychological operations, or "psy-ops," uniquely equips her to understand the ritual's institutional function and value within the Church.

... my background... in the military, I did intel, and I did psy-ops. So, you look at it, and you're like, "Oh, I understand why the Catholic Church is hated so much," because it is the direct contradiction— and it is the— the sacraments of the Catholic Church are basically the prescription for what ails our society. Everything up from baptism, to last rites— everything that's going on in our society, and the way that our government operates— the whole purpose of psyops, information warfare, psychological warfare— it's all about forced moral corruption. It's about figuring out your values and your principles, and using them against you, right? ... the sacraments are the counter to that— the antidote to those things... even if you screw up and you do something wrong, that's where confession is so significant. - Sarah, lay parishioner

Through her experiences conducting "information warfare" for the government, Sarah is able to make sense of the logic that structures confession. While striking, this comparison reflects a keen observation of the ritual as an analogous exercise of institutional power and influence with concrete objectives. Using Catholic "psy-ops," the Church similarly builds, and reconstructs penitents' moral foundation at the level of their individual bodies. However, this process is not autonomous or terminal, and instead (re)produces subjectivity in a variety of corporeal forms, unique to each individual. Through confession, the Church gains penitents' active compliance in

(re)shaping their lived bodies, deploying them ‘in the field’ as effective *agents* of the institution, rather than God. Individuals therefore sustain themselves [and their bodies] through the Church, and the Church sustains itself through individuals [and their bodies]. The ritual facilitates the complete integration of these corporeal and institutional structures; as a recursive interaction through which the two continuously (re)produce each other, and ensure their *mutual* survival.

DISCUSSION

This study seeks to demonstrate the phenomenon of confession through the lived experiences of Catholic priests and parishioners. The sacrament is unique to Catholicism, and predicated on the Church’s promise¹² that penitents’ sins will be kept completely anonymous and private— known only by God [and the priest]. These distinct structural properties make it impossible to observe the ritual in practice. In lieu of this direct perspective, this study examines penitents’ lived experiences preparing for, participating in, and making sense of the ritual, as the next available source of empirical data. This analysis draws from over 50 hours of semi-structured, ethnographic interviews, in which 32 priests and parishioners detail their first-hand accounts, and holistic interpretations of the ritual.

Though this approach examines confession from a necessary distance, the insight it provides is no less thorough. This study delineates a complete account of the ritual from both individual and institutional perspectives, by first asking how priests and lay parishioners experience it themselves. Interviewees demonstrate that confession is a fundamentally embodied practice; describing the corporeal effects it (re)produces, and performances it requires. These data reveal how penitents experience (im)morality as somatic sensations of sin and forgiveness.

¹² See Footnote 6 for a description of the “Seal of Confession,” which is the Church policy that requires the ritual to remain entirely confidential.

Using diverse discursive frames, interviewees situate their immorality externally— as burdens, constraints, dirt, and stains— or internally— as physiological ailments, disabilities, injuries, and sicknesses. By (re)constructing sin in and through their lived bodies, interviewees reveal that confession not only transforms them morally, but also *corporeally*. These findings build on prior sociological studies of rituals that identify the somatic effects of spiritual interactions and religious belief (Csordas 1997, Glassman 2017, Inbody 2015, Krotofil et al. 2021, Winchester and Pagis 2021, Winchester 2008). While strands of current literature describe how faith-based practices produce somatic experiences, this analysis goes even further by tracing confession's structural origins and implications within the Church and social world, more broadly.

The unique discursive frames interviewees use to articulate their embodied (im)morality also delineate an institutional perspective of the ritual, revealing that its practical function is far more complex than its espoused purpose of forgiveness. By locating sin in relation to their lived bodies, interviewees simultaneously locate themselves in relation to the Church— identifying how the institution facilitates their corporeal transformations. Their individual, embodied (re)constructions of sin, entail analogous definitions of the Church's role in this process. Corporeal frameworks that externalize or internalize interviewees' bodily (im)morality indirectly describe how the Church frees, cleanses, and heals them from sin. Through confession, penitents' experience sin as not only a threat to their morality, but also their physiological health and well being. In this way, both the ritual and the Church become essential for their actual— rather than merely spiritual— survival. Interviewees describe this embodied dependence through their observations of tangible improvements in their physical appearance and capacities, only possible through confession. These accounts demonstrate the ritual's functional (re)production of the Church's power, through interviewees' lived experiences of its somatic effects. Priests' and

parishioners' embodied accounts trace confession's institutional structure by identifying the Church's explicit role in their moral and corporeal (re)formation. These findings build on prior studies that identify analogous phenomena in a variety of other social contexts; delineating how individuals' bodies are strategically (re)shaped by moralized practices within different religious and secular institutions (Guhin 2021; Garcia 2010, Gerber 2009, Guhin 2021, Johnson 2010, Kurri and Wahlström 2001, Ignatow 2009, Mahmood 2012, Powell et al 2017).

The Structure of Confession: Relating the Body, Power, Duality, and Agency

Existing studies of similar rituals define this phenomenon as either the conflation of subjective somatic experiences with intangible spirituality, or all-consuming external mechanisms of autonomous power and control. This analysis unites these dichotomous conceptualizations by theorizing confession's *recursive* structure. These data reveal the ritual's duality (Giddens 1984), as penitents' experience of both their own lived corporeality, and the Church's broad power. By applying a structural lens to interviewees' accounts, this study reveals how confession systematically integrates individual and institutional schemas as a composite, embodied whole. Unique somatic descriptions and experiences of (im)morality demonstrate how the Church's moral logic of sin is corporealized and naturalized as a part of priests' and parishioners' bodies. These individual and institutional schemas are thus enmeshed in confession, and reflexively interact with one another; as penitents (re)form sin to "fit" within their bodies, and sin (re)forms penitents' bodies to "fit" within the Church.

This study's structural perspective connects these analytical findings to its central empirical questions. Interviewees' lived accounts demonstrate both their subjectivity, and how confession requires penitents and the Church to work together by (re)producing it in a variety of corporeal forms—specific to their individual bodies. By delineating penitents' unique

externalizations and internalizations of sin, and tracing their systematic (re)construction, this analysis not only establishes which embodied institutional schemas exist, but asks why they exist in such different forms all at once. How is it possible that the same, systematically structured ritual is experienced as somatically “freeing” and “cleansing” by some interviewees, and physiologically “healing” and rehabilitating by others? Despite institutional narratives of its rigid and uniform procedure, interviewees’ descriptions of its incredibly diverse embodied effects reveal confession is essentially non-uniform. In this way, penitents not only depend on the ritual—and the Church—to preserve their moral well being, but also to sustain their physical health and actual survival.

While confession involves an organized series of bodily practices to integrate corporeal and institutional structures, this reflexive model of confession also paradoxically demonstrates its inherent fluidity. Rather than simply facilitating the deterministic (re)production of a singular embodied subjectivity, the ritual allows and requires penitents to exercise their individual *agency*. Through their highly personalized descriptions and experiences of corporeal (im)morality, interviewees ensure that the power of both confession, and the Church are virtually unlimited and unquestionable. By agentially (re)shaping their lived bodies alongside the Church, penitents not only posit the ritual’s potential to affect drastic moral transformations, but also create tangible evidence of them—describing how the Church facilitates everything from somatic feelings of “lightness” and “cleanliness,” to the miraculous healing of their physiological afflictions and injuries. This analysis therefore reveals that confession structures and interdependent and recursive relationship between penitents and the Church. Through the ritual, interviewees not only depend on the institution for their individual survival, but the institution

also depends on them; equally reliant on agents as corporeal evidence of confession, and the Church's unbounded power, and perpetual necessity.

This theoretical framework delineates a complete account of the ritual. While dynamic and flexible, the structure of confession is essentially distinguished by four dimensions. First, interviewees' somatic accounts of sin, forgiveness, and their participation as confessors or penitents, demonstrate that the ritual is fundamentally (1) embodied. By defining (im)morality corporeally, interviewees identify the Church's role in (re)shaping penitents' bodies and thus reveal confession's functional (re)production of (2) institutional power. Together, these perspectives establish the ritual's (3) duality, as the systematic integration of individual bodies with the institution's moral logic of sin. The final, fourth dimension of confession is critical to distinguish in relation to its other qualities. Throughout sociological literature and empirical traditions, elements of structural language commonly denote stasis (Sewell 1992). This study employs a more dynamic perspective of confession's systematic structure, requisite [corporeal and institutional] schemas, and recursivity. These data and analysis demonstrate that the ritual is not perpetually (re)productive of a uniform embodied subjectivity. Rather, interviewees describe how individuals and the Church work together in (re)constructing this dynamic as diverse, personalized corporeal schemas. Though the bodily practices confession requires are systematically organized and operationalized throughout this process, it also relies significantly on penitents' own (4) agency. As both (re)shaped by, and encouraged to (re)shape their embodied (im)morality, interviewees allow the Church to maximize both its own, and the ritual's power. By critically analyzing all aspects of confession's structure, this study therefore argues that the ritual facilitates an interdependent interaction between penitents and the Church, through which individuals and the institution ensure their mutual survival.

(Re)Producing Power: Implications Within Catholicism

These findings have significant implications within the specific context of the Church. As both priests and parishioners recognize, many aspects of their lived experiences challenge the ritual's theological structure and rationale espoused by the institution. While interviewees consistently describe somatic sensations of sin, they acknowledge only feeling forgiveness somewhat sporadically in confession. Despite the Church's teaching that absolution is unconditional, these data demonstrate the ritual's practical unreliability. Both priests and parishioners attribute these functional abnormalities to a variety of mistakes confessors and penitents make in adhering to its prescribed institutional structure. Interviewees delineate personal strategies for negotiating both their own, and others' inability to perform their roles as penitents or confessors correctly— failing to disclose all of their sins, recite required prayers verbatim, or demonstrate authentic contrition and engagement. Regardless of how the ritual went awry, interviewees explain their lingering sensations of immorality as embodied individual pathologies, rather than institutional— or divine— errors. In this way, interviewees' bodies are not only intrinsically liable for their sins, but also for confession's inefficacy; as God was unable to forgive them in the past because of their embodied unworthiness. Before somatically experiencing a “successful” confession, Laura, and several other interviewees describe persistent corporeal sensations as evidence they were *too sinful* for the ritual to adequately address their embodied immorality.

*It [finally being forgiven in confession] was so powerful... it just made me feel worthy. I guess, I guess **I had carried around for a long time this feeling of unworthiness**, or maybe I felt like I was unclean... - Laura, lay parishioner*

This perspective, as expressed by multiple priests and parishioners, both reifies and reinforces a static, unidirectional conceptualization of the relationship between penitents and the Church. In

this framework, individuals are entirely dependent on confession and the institution, as the sole source of extracting their deeply rooted corporeal immorality. Without the ritual, or the Church, penitents are intrinsically sinful and undeserving of God's forgiveness— to which they should have unrestricted access.

This analysis posits an alternative view of this relationship, describing confession's duality and reflexivity. Interviewees' lived experiences demonstrate their embodied dependence on the Church for both moral, and even physiological survival. However, by tracing the individual corporeal schemas of their subjectivity, this study also provides *living* evidence of penitents' agency. This theory of confession's duly embodied and institutional structure, upsets the power differential between penitents and the Church (re)produced by both the ritual, and other practical interactions. Through their agentic (re)construction of the ritual as personalized discursive frames for their corporeal (im)morality, interviewees demonstrate the Church's reliance on penitents' bodies. This interdependent relationship thus lays the groundwork for a systematic challenge to the institution's authority on both organizational, and interactional scales. Understanding how penitents and the Church rely on each other in confession, to preserve their mutual survival— rather than solely penitents relying on the Church— provides a critical lens through which the functional purpose of other Catholic practices, and the hierarchy of power they reify, can be analyzed empirically. This theoretical perspective is particularly well-positioned to both explain how these structures are regularly (re)produced within the Church, and identify how their unique qualities may be exploited in service of explicitly malicious institutional and individual agendas. Recognizing agency in this context encourages more complex, and effective interventions in response to blatant abuses of power; shifting liability from individual actors, to institutional structures of domination. Instead of punitively

removing “bad apples,” remedies grounded in this perspective can be structured to address wrongdoing systematically, as it is hidden and supported by the Church’s larger infrastructure.

Analogous Structures: Implications Outside Catholicism

This study’s model of confession’s structure, duly composed of corporeal and institutional schemas, implies its functional transposability. The ritual’s virtual composition translates directly to agents, practices, and contexts that are structurally similar to penitents, confession, and the Church (Sewell 1992). Existing research locates the systematic (re)production of analogous embodied and institutional schemas within a variety of religious and secular contexts. While few employ an explicitly structural approach, these studies demonstrate how individual bodies both (re)shape and are (re)shaped by schools, governments, law enforcement agencies, courts, psychiatric counseling, and wellness programs (Garcia 2010, Gerber 2009, Guhin 2021, Johnson 2010, Kurri and Wahlström 2001, Ignatow 2009, Powell et al. 2017). Scholars identify the corporeal (im)morality penitents embody through confession in each of these contexts, as specific to the bodily practices they prescribe.

Similar phenomena are most commonly analyzed in legal and medical institutions. Through strategic policymaking, governments and legislatures define “good citizens” by their corporeal characteristics; regulating the public actions and appearances of embodied others to prevent them from harming society’s otherwise moral state (Garcia 2010). Law enforcement agencies employ targeted policing practices by over-disciplining specific activities to situate those who engage in them— and others that share their embodied identities— as immoral and “criminal” (Johnson 2010). Defense lawyers and prosecutors reconstruct victims’ physical appearances and comportments throughout their live testimony as evidence of their credibility, or immoral deception (Powell et al 2017). Weight loss programs, offered by specific Christian and

Evangelical denominations, link sin to obesity through the frame of gluttony; explicitly identifying thinner bodies as moral ones (Gerber 2009, Ignatow 2009). Through confession, the Catholic Church identifies “sinners” as penitents who *feel and look* burdened, dirty, and sick. Each of these institutions effectively (re)produces the same corporeal schemas of (im)morality in different forms— unique to subjects’ individual bodies.

This study’s phenomenological account of confession’s structure provides a theoretical framework to critically analyze not only other Catholic and religious rituals, but moralized bodily practices more generally. As identified by substantial strands of sociological literature, analogous embodied institutional schemas are pervasive throughout a wide range of social contexts. Relying exclusively on interviewees’ accounts of the ritual, this study demonstrates how broader institutional structures, like those of confession and the Church, are traceable through individual lived experiences. This analysis delineates a strategy for identifying and analyzing corporeal descriptions as credible evidence of [moral] subjectivity. Understanding how “sinners” are (re)produced in confession through their (im)moral sensations, makes it possible to observe the ritual’s practical function, and institutional purpose. Applying this empirical perspective to analogous structures in other contexts therefore empowers future analyses to go beyond either describing corporeal schemas of subjectivity, or mapping their external (re)production. Instead, this study advocates for a reflexive approach that delineates both of these embodied individual and institutional structures simultaneously, to expose how they influence and interact with one another.

Limitations and Directions for Future Research

The scope of this study creates several opportunities for rich analysis, through a variety of critical lenses. While these findings represent a comprehensive overview of the data, several

empirical and theoretical perspectives remain unexplored. Interviewees' accounts demonstrate the systematic power of the Church's unique institutional framework, and hierarchical organization. Embodied descriptions of confession by all 32 priests and parishioners included in this study demonstrate significant differences between their lived experiences. However, this analysis would be considerably enriched by a more diverse range of interviewees, as well as the formal measurement of their distinct demographic characteristics and identities. Sociological understandings of confession would also be advanced by an even broader comparison of populations; analyzing not only the experiences of current members, but also those of ex-members whom the ritual failed to successfully "welcome into" the Church through its Catholic "psy-ops." Alongside an expanded sample, the ethnographic quality of these data may also be enhanced by different collection methods. Rather than meeting with priests and parishioners individually, interviews with groups, pairs, or couples and spouses are a valuable opportunity to observe how confession's structure (re)shapes other embodied interactions and relationships that members experience— both within and outside the Church. This study's framework is not only applicable to other observations of confession, but also to other institutional schemas within Catholicism. While incredibly important, the ritual is only one of several practices through which members' bodies are (re)inscribed with the Church's logic and power. Subsequent analyses of other Catholic sacraments and more ubiquitous, informal interactions from this theoretical perspective would significantly advance these findings; identifying how the systematic cultivation of embodied subjectivity facilitated by confession, occurs throughout the Church more broadly. All of these empirical adjustments lay the groundwork for further sociological analyses of both the ritual specifically, and the institutional dynamics it embodies.

Sample Size and Diversity

These data depict a wide range of interviewees' embodied subjectivity within the Church. From cinder blocks and stray french fries, to life-threatening psychological and physical afflictions, priests and parishioners in this study demonstrate incredibly diverse externalized and internalized somatic descriptions of sin. However, the Church's vast membership of over 1.3 billion individuals, provides a near endless supply of potential perspectives. Just as the institution holds that penitents have only begun to understand the full scope of their immorality in confession, sociologists have only begun to understand the full scope of the ritual itself. This study's methodological and theoretical framework is limited to only two midwestern Catholic dioceses, and should be expanded to include a much larger number of interviewees. An increased sample size would extend these findings by presenting an expanded view of the individual agency this study depicts, and additional evidence of its essential role in confession.

This analysis identifies thematic patterns throughout the substantive content of these data—examining the influence of penitents' lived experiences within confession to delineate a theory of its structure. This perspective is not only enhanced by additional interviewees, but also by the formal measurement of their demographic characteristics and identities (i.e. gender identity, race and ethnicity, socioeconomic status, education, profession, etc.). With this supplemental data, future studies should also examine the influence of penitents' lived experiences *outside* confession, and the Church, to delineate a more comprehensive and holistic theory of the ritual's structure. These descriptive variables introduce an additional layer of analysis by providing insight into how broader social—rather than exclusively Catholic—identities and histories also (re)shape how the Church's moral logic is embodied. Applying this study's theoretical framework to a wider dataset may expose underlying connections that

distinguish certain individuals as predisposed to moral externalism or internalism, and particular somatic experiences of sin. Further insight into the unique structural qualities of penitents' corporeal schemas may reveal whether their (re)production in confession is gendered, raced, or otherwise influenced by embodied social identities.

This study theorizes the ritual's structure through diverse accounts of its function(s); mapping how different penitents somatically sense sin and forgiveness. However, confession may also be analyzed inversely, by examining the lived experiences of those who do not sense their (im)morality at all—intentionally refusing to embody the Church's logic. Accounts of ex-Catholics, who were disillusioned or repelled by the ritual, provide a robust opportunity for sociological comparison. Future research should develop a more complete model of confession's function, by exploring cases that demonstrate how it failed to altogether. Those who actively resist the ritual, and the Church, may provide the most explicit critiques of its power. By examining alternative, and even hostile perspectives, these studies could offer extremely granular insight into the interaction; identifying its specific structural qualities that deter some penitents from embodying the moral logic of sin, while actively encouraging others.

Interview Methods

In addition to their substantive content, interviews were a significant source of supplementary ethnographic data, as intensely embodied experiences themselves. Their agile and open-ended format facilitated unique interpersonal interactions between myself and interviewees. In the absence of direct observation, these interviews provided essential insight into power dynamics this study identifies through confession. Unsure of how they should approach each conversation, several interviewees— and priests especially— (re)produced the ritual's structure within our interaction; claiming the institutional role and authority established by the ritual

through various discursive strategies. These intensely reflexive [and embodied] experiences yielded considerable insight into confession, beyond interviewees' lived accounts. Future research should explore the effects of this methodology further, and experiment with different approaches to maximize the ethnographic quality of these data.

This study's interview protocol is transposable to a variety of dyadic and small group formats. Subsequent analyses of confession, and this phenomenon more generally, should conduct interviews with several priests and parishioners at once, rather than individually. Arranging interviews in groups, pairs, or even specific forms of these relationships— such as Catholic couples and spouses¹³ – would increase the phenomenological and ethnographic character of this analysis. Using this methodology will expose the ritual's practical dimensions through their discursive co-construction and interpretation. Observing how multiple interviewees *interact* to describe confession as an *interaction* provides additional insight into the functional (re)production of their embodied (im)morality within the ritual, and the institution more broadly. This perspective invites further sociological exploration of how the Church's moral logic of sin may influence or compete with other institutional and relational schemas penitents embody. Future research may build on these findings by examining how intrinsic sinfulness (re)shapes not only penitents' individual bodies, but also their social roles and responsibilities as partners, parents, peers, and professionals, within and outside the Church.

Other Catholic Practices

Interviewees' lived experiences of confession delineate a condensed model of the Church's institutional structure through their corporealized (im)morality. This study traces the

¹³ Parishioners Sarah and Matt were interviewed together, as a married couple. This created an opportunity to analyze confession using a more dynamic methodology, as these interviewees assumed different discursive tasks in (re)constructing their own— and each others' – lived experiences of the ritual. Further studies should investigate how this embodied labor is distributed, and analyze structural similarities between these interactions and confession.

institutional (re)production of interviewees' embodied subjectivity through confession, exclusively. However, this ritual is only one of seven formal Church sacraments, and countless other, informal interactions that function in similar ways. Given that empirical studies of Catholicism and Catholic rituals are already incredibly rare, further research is necessary to not only understand confession, but also the Church more broadly. Future studies of Catholic embodied practices and relationships should continue to explore the institution's structure; identifying and analyzing how its power is (re)produced in a wider variety of corporeal forms and contexts. By increasing the breadth of these data, subsequent research may operationalize this study's theoretical framework to delineate a more complete account of the Church's overarching institutional structure, as a systematic whole of several transformative practices aimed at (re)forming members' lived bodies. Future studies should also problematize not only how other sacraments function, but also how all seven are temporally organized by the Church. These inquiries create the potential to develop longitudinal theories for how the Church strategically (re)produces members' bodies throughout their lifetimes, rather than within a single ritual. Such macro-level understandings of Catholicism would still benefit from a phenomenological perspective, informed by empirical observations at the level of individual embodiment. This interactionist analysis demonstrates the lived experience of Church membership directly and dynamically, rather than through institutional frameworks.

CONCLUSION

This study seeks to understand (1) how Catholic priests and parishioners experience the sacrament of confession, (2) how it functions in practice, and (3) how it structures individuals' relationships with the Church. Through the phenomenological lens of interviewees' lived

experiences, these data demonstrate the fundamentally embodied experience of confession. Through highly personalized discursive frames, priests and parishioners describe somatic sensations of sin and forgiveness, revealing how the ritual facilitates both their moral and corporeal transformations. In confession, penitents are (re)shaped by the Church's logic of sin—situating (im)morality as external or internal to their lived bodies. However, these data reveal how penitents also (re)shape sin to “fit” their bodies. This interdependent relationship not only allows, but actively relies on penitents' agentic (re)constructions of their corporeal (im)morality to substantiate the virtually unlimited power of confession, and the Church. It is only through these unique embodied descriptions that it becomes plausible for the same ritual to both “free” penitents from sin, and “heal” them from the physical afflictions it entails. This analysis posits a theory of confession's *recursive* structure as the systematic integration of corporeal and institutional schemas that continuously, and fluidly (re)produce one another through the ritual. This study therefore argues that confession facilitates the interdependent relationship between penitents and the Church, revealing how individuals and the institution rely on the ritual for their *mutual* embodied survival. These findings extend sociological studies of the lived body, religious rituals, institutional power, and Catholicism, specifically. Both within, and beyond the Church, this study's methodology and theoretical perspective provides a sociological framework to critically examine moralized bodily practices in a wide range of religious and secular institutions; mapping the recursive structural integration and functional (re)production of embodied agency and subjectivity.

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APPENDIX A

All *[NAME OF PARISH]* parishioners! My name is Ella Engquist, and I am a rising senior studying sociology at the University of Michigan. This summer, I am conducting research for my senior honors thesis about the importance of Catholic confession. As a lifelong Catholic myself, I am curious about others' experiences with the sacrament, and how they understand it. Please note that I am interested in *how* you've experienced confession, not *what* you've confessed, and **you will never be required or expected to talk about the details of your sins or private discussions with priests**. Throughout June, July, and August, I hope to speak with parishioners about these topics through 45-60 minute, informal, open-ended interviews (though longer timeframes are more than welcome!). Our conversation will simply be a space to talk about confession freely, and explore your experiences with it in whatever way you see fit. If you choose to speak with me, everything we discuss will be kept confidential, and your identity will remain anonymous. If you have questions about my research or are interested in participating, you can reach me at ellengq@umich.edu, or (231) 872-9024.

Interest/Availability Form: <https://forms.gle/cNx5CAc6YZTiZVPB8>

APPENDIX B

Confession Research Participation

My name is Ella Engquist, and I am a rising senior studying sociology at the University of Michigan. This Fall, I am conducting research for my senior honors thesis about the importance of Catholic confession. As a lifelong Catholic myself, I am curious about others' experiences with the sacrament, and how they understand it. Please note that I am interested in *how* you've experienced confession, not *what* you've confessed, and **you will never be required or expected to talk about the details of your sins or private discussions with priests**. Throughout the next few weeks, I hope to speak with parishioners about these topics through 45-60 minute, informal, open-ended interviews (though longer timeframes are more than welcome!). Our conversation will simply be a space to talk about confession freely, and explore your experiences with it in whatever way you see fit. If you choose to speak with me, everything we discuss will be kept confidential, and your identity will remain anonymous.

Please fill in the information below if you are interested in participating, and I will contact you within 24-48 hours to schedule an interview for a time that works best for you.

****All interviews will be conducted virtually (on Zoom, or another virtual platform you can access).****

If you have additional questions about my research, you can reach me at ellengq@umich.edu.

Thank you!

ellengq@umich.edu [Switch account](#)



*** Indicates required question**

Email *

Your email

What is your name? (First, Last) *

Your answer

What is the name of your Parish? *

Your answer

Please provide an email/phone number you can be reached at. *

Your answer

What is your availability (Mondays-Sundays) for an interview? Please list specific date/times you would prefer, below. *

**Limited availability on Tuesdays only.*

Your answer

Are you be able to attend the interview virtually (on Zoom)? *

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ I would prefer a different virtual meeting platform.

If you prefer a different virtual meeting platform, please list it here:

Your answer

Do you have any questions/concerns about this project? If so, please list them below, and I will address them when contacting you!

Your answer

Thank you for your interest!

You can expect a response within the next 24-48 hours.

See the University of Michigan Department of Sociology's website for additional information about the Senior Thesis + Honors

Program: <https://lsa.umich.edu/soc/undergraduates/honors-program.html>

☐ Send me a copy of my responses.

Submit

Clear form

APPENDIX C

Interview Guide– Lay Members/General
Ella Engquist

Introduction

Thank you for coming today! For this first part, I am going to read you some basic information about me and my project. I'm telling you this because it may feel unnatural to start a conversation this way, but it's just something I have to do to create a bit of consistency in these interviews. I want to make sure I'm setting the same scene for everyone, and I don't influence your answers. This section is short, but it's not formal at all; so please stop me if you have questions or something doesn't make sense!

- I am a Junior at the University of Michigan, majoring in sociology. I am interested in learning more about the importance of confession (or reconciliation) in the Catholic Church.
- By talking to [*Catholics, priests, or teachers/administrators*] like yourself, I am hoping to explore all parts of the sacrament from an embodied perspective; this means I am curious about not only your perceptions of reconciliation, but also your experiences participating in it.
- As a Catholic myself, I have attended Catholic schools nearly my entire life and gone to confession countless times. Through this project, I want to talk with others about their experiences with this sacrament to understand their perspective.
- This is simply a space for you to discuss reconciliation freely, and explore your experiences in whatever way you see fit. My questions for you are open-ended, so don't worry about answering them exactly or talking about other things– just share what feels important to you.
- Having participated in it myself, I understand confession is a very personal experience, so I want you to know that anything you decide to share with me will only be used for academic purposes. Also, you are not required to answer my questions if you're not comfortable, and all aspects of your participation are voluntary.
- With your permission, I would like to record this conversation so that we can talk more casually and I can refer back to it later. If you're not comfortable with this, that is also completely fine; just know that you might see me writing a few things down to remind me of parts of our discussion, in the future.
- Notes and recordings (*if given permission*) from our conversation will be kept completely confidential, and I will not use your name or other personal identifying information in order to protect your privacy.

Background in Catholicism

1. Tell me a bit about yourself.
 - a. How long have you been Catholic?
 - i. [not raised Catholic]: Tell me about how you came to the Church.

- ii. [raised Catholic]: Tell me about growing up in the Church.

Experiences with First Confession

- 2. I'm interested in how you came to the faith, in part, because I want to know about your First Confession/Reconciliation. Can you tell me about that?

- a. Tell me about the process of preparation you went through.
 - i. Were you a part of a program? Did you have to complete certain steps?
 - ii. Did you go to a class? Did you have to do readings?
 - iii. How did all of this work?
 - 1. What did this process involve?
 - 2. Who did this process involve?
 - 3. How long did it take?
- b. Can you set the scene for the day of your first reconciliation? What do you remember?
 - i. Where are you?
 - ii. Who are you with?
 - iii. What are you thinking about? What are you feeling?
 - iv. What do you notice about the people around you? What are they saying?
What are they doing?
 - v. What are you doing [*first, next, after that, etc.*]?
 - vi. Can you tell me about going into the confessional room for the first time?
 - 1. What are you seeing?
 - 2. What are you thinking? What are you feeling?

3. What are you doing?
4. What do you notice about the priest?
- vii. I want to be clear that I don't need or want you to tell me what you said, or the sins that you confessed. Can you tell me about the experience of talking to the priest?
 1. What are you doing in the room?
 2. What are you thinking about? What are you feeling?
 3. What is the priest doing? What is the priest saying?
- viii. Tell me about what happened after you finished confessing.
 1. Where are you? Where do you go after leaving the confessional?
 2. What are you thinking about? What are you feeling?
 3. What are you doing?
- c. Did you ever talk about that experience with anyone? Tell me about those conversations.
 - i. Who did you talk to?
 - ii. How did they talk about confession? What was important to them about it?
 1. What did they ask you about your experience?
 2. Did they offer you advice or other information?
 - iii. What did you tell them?

Current Relationship to Confession and Continued Experiences

3. To preface my next question, I want you to know that I haven't been to confession in almost five years, and you can rest assured that I'm not judging you. Do you still go to confession?
 - a. Tell me about that decision. (*skip to section d.*)
 - b. [still attend]: How often? Do you attend on a regular basis– weekly, monthly, yearly?
 - i. What brings you back to confession?
 - ii. How do you know when you need to confess? Tell me about how you decide when to go.
 - iii. Tell me about what you do when you go to confession.
 1. Do you have a routine?
 2. Do things change? What causes these changes?
 - c. [still attend]: Can you set the scene for me again? This time, describe how you typically go about attending confession.
 - i. Tell me about the time leading up to your confession, after you've decided to go.
 1. Do you do anything to prepare?
 2. What are you thinking about? What are you doing? What are you feeling?
 - ii. Tell me about what you do when you get to the Church.
 1. Where are you?
 2. What are you thinking about? What are you feeling?

3. What's happening around you?
4. What are you doing [*first, next, after that, etc.*]?
5. Can you tell me about entering the confessional room?
 - i. What are you seeing?
 - ii. What are you thinking? What are you feeling?
 - iii. What are you doing?
 - iv. What is the priest doing?
6. Again, I don't need or want you to tell me what you say, or the sins that you confess. Can you tell me about the experience of talking to the priest?
 - i. What are you doing in the room?
 - ii. What are you thinking about? What are you feeling?
 - iii. What is the priest doing? What is the priest saying?
 - b. Tell me about what happened after your confession.
 - i. What are you doing next?
 - ii. Where are you?
 - iii. What are you thinking about? What are you feeling?
7. Do you ever talk about your confession with anyone? Tell me about those conversations.
 - a. Who do you talk to?
 - b. How have they talked about confession? What seems important to them about it?
 - i. What do they ask you about your experience?

- ii. Do they offer you advice or other information?
 - c. What do you tell them?
- d. [no longer attend]: Tell me about your decision to stop going to confession.
 - i. After your first reconciliation, how long did you attend confession before deciding to stop?
 - 1. How often did you confess?
 - 2. Tell me about why you continued to go back during that time.
 - 3. Tell me about how you decided when to confess.
 - 4. Can you tell me about those experiences?
 - a. What happened?
 - b. What would you do after you left the confessional room?
 - c. What were you thinking about? What were you feeling?
 - ii. What keeps you from going now?
 - 1. Did you make a decision not to stop going at a certain point in time?
 - 2. [if yes]: When was this? Why then?
 - 3. Tell me about making that decision.
 - iii. Would you ever go back to confession? Why?
 - 1. Has anyone ever encouraged you to? Tell me about what that was like.
 - a. What happened?
 - b. How did it make you feel?
 - c. What did it make you think about?

- e. Now that we've talked about your experiences with confession, I am curious about how you feel about it more generally– beyond how you've experienced it in specific moments.
 - i. Could you tell me a little more about the kind of role confession plays in your life?
 - 1. Do you only think about it when you decide to go? What is its presence like in your life generally, and within the Church?
 - a. How do you think your relationship with confession squares with the Church's definition of the sacrament?
 - i. Does it align? Does it look different? Tell me about that.
 - ii. Tell me about the role you think confession as a sacrament, not just in your own life, plays in the Catholic Church and faith.
 - 1. Is it necessary? Why or why not?
 - 2. Can it be replaced by or substituted with something else? Why or why not? What might this look like?
 - iii. Do you do anything similar to confess or repent for your sins, without going to a priest? Tell me about that.
 - 1. What does that look like?
 - 2. Tell me about its effect on you. Do you feel the same as you do after talking to the priest?
 - a. When did you start doing this?
 - b. Why did you?

- c. Tell me about how it makes you feel.
- d. Tell me about why you continue this practice.

Closing

- Thank you so much for talking to me today. I know confession is a really personal topic and experience, so I appreciate your openness in sharing everything you did– it is going to add so much to my study!
- Is there anything else you want me to know, or that you feel like you didn't get a chance to tell me about?
- Do you have any questions for me?
- Do you know (of) anyone else who might be interested in speaking with me? *(if so, offer your personal contact information; phone number and email address).*

**Ensure the recording is turned off and saved.*

**Take notes about important information from the interview.*

**Write and reflect: How did you feel talking to them? How do you feel now?*

APPENDIX D

Interview(s) No.:

Group:

[Coded identifiers for the interview or analytical group of interviews are listed here. Individual case memos are only identified by their assigned number, while analytical group memos include these in addition to the name and conceptualization of the corresponding group. Final memo(s) analyzing the dataset as a whole indicate such objectives here.]

Demographics:

[Relevant/unique demographic details concerning each case, or analytical group are listed here. This includes general notes, in addition to specific characteristics outlined by the categories listed below.]

- Lay member or minister?: *[Member/minister]*
- Location: *[Grand Rapids Archdiocese/Lansing Archdiocese, rural/suburban/urban/other]*
- Gender: *[binary sex (not individually reported)]*
- Race: *[White, Black, etc. (not individually reported)]*
- Age: *[young adult, middle aged, senior (not individually reported)]*
- Church History/Involvement: *[raised in Church/converted, # of years as priest/parishioner, family involvement, current activities]*

Interview Story/ies:

[The embodied experience of the interview is detailed here. Substantively, this can include; participants' accounts of confession, experiences in the Church more broadly, descriptions of embodied (im)morality, etc.]

Key Concepts:

[Important topics are noted here, in addition to terms that describe the specific moralized language and metaphors participants used to discuss their experiences; i.e. "Lightness/Heaviness" or "Clean/Unclean", etc.]

Key Excerpts:

[Direct quotes that best represent the interview's main themes or conversational experience are detailed here. This includes statements that evince the Interview Story/ies, and key concepts that were identified.]

APPENDIX E

Group: GROUP NAME

Interviewees: n = TOTAL NUMBER IN GROUP

1. CODED ID

Group Summary:

Demographic Details:

Identify interviewees' ages, professions, childhood experiences (i.e. raised Catholic, Catholic family?), professions, and other notable characteristics.

Executive Summary:

Executive summary of distinct characteristics and themes unique to the analytical group. Include excerpts as relevant evidence of summary conclusions. Identify key concepts discussed and implications for analysis.

Differences Within Group:

Bulleted list with brief descriptions and explanations of each point. Use this to list potential subjects of thematic memos. Identify and describe key distinctions among individual interviewees. How do these interviewees differ or contradict one another? Include excerpts as relevant evidence of summary conclusions. Why are these distinctions important? What do they mean? Are there any patterns?

Differences From Other Groups:

Bulleted list with brief descriptions and explanations of each point. Use this to list potential subjects of thematic memos. Identify and describe key distinctions among analytical groups. How does this group differ or contradict others? Include excerpts as relevant evidence of summary conclusions. Why are these distinctions important? What do they mean? Are there any patterns?

Key Concepts and Excerpts:

- **CONCEPT:**
 - *Excerpts (INTERVIEW #)*

APPENDIX F

Thematic Memo #- THEME

Area of focus.

Identify notable interviews/cases; which heavily informed analysis, which were irrelevant?

Interviewees:

**Highly relevant/influential interviewees are marked by an asterisk*

- F/P #
- F/P#
- F/P#
- F/P#
- F/P#
- F/P#
- F/P#
- F/P#
- F/P#
- F/P#

Executive Summary:

Subtheme 1

Subtheme 2

Subtheme 3

Key Excerpts

Other Notes/Observations: